

Visiting Hours

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Cities, like dreams, are made of desires and fears...

Italo Calvino

Invisible Cities

Translated by William Weaver

*Was he free? Was he happy? The question is absurd:
Had anything been wrong, we should certainly have heard.*

W. H. Auden

The Unknown Citizen

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FORM 1 • REGISTRATION OF A NEW ARRIVAL

Office of the Standard Version. Complete in ink, within the first hour. No charge is made for this form.

1	Name		ruled through at the printer's, before issue
2	Household		
3	Hill, lane, door		
4	Arrived from		not required
5	Reason for leaving		the last address; a dash is accepted
6	Words held on arrival		of proven retention; audited at the ramp
7	Purpose of stay		I decline to state one. This box is provided.
8	Anyone who may be called		and at what hour
9	Anyone who may not		
10	Duration of stay		leave blank. This office will complete the field.

Grace period: twelve hours from the first breath. No charge accrues during it. The use of it is recorded.

Signature of the person, unnamed above	Date	Witnessed by
	the hour, if known	a member of staff, who did not look up

Retain this form. A copy is issued at the standard rate.

Part I

Registration

Many Happy Returns

story one

On the morning of his seventh birthday the boy wakes before the city does. He lies still while it catches up to him — a shutter going up, a dog with an opinion, the first feet of the day on the stair street. He has a loose tooth. He works it with his tongue, saving it.

From the kitchen, his mother beating eggs with a fork — the mixer frightens the batter, she says, and not today of all days. Lemon. There will be lemon under her nails until evening, and a fresh burn across her wrist, the old scar renewed annually.

His father stands on a chair with a nail between his lips. The banner hangs crooked over the balcony door. It will hang crooked at every party this room ever holds.

The apartment sits three floors above the café that lends out its chairs for every wedding, funeral and birthday on the hill. The stair street has a hundred and twelve steps, a dry fountain at the fortieth, laundry crossing overhead like signal flags. At the top a transformer hums one low note the neighborhood has agreed not to hear. From the balcony the boy can see the far hill with its cranes, building the same building since before he was born. Under everything, the water — a river or a sea, depending on which way the wind is working. Behind the flat, where the stair street gives out, is the hill nobody in this room has ever had a reason to climb. The morning smells of frying from the café, bleach from the stairwell, drains breathing after last night's rain.

The table has been lengthened with the spare-room door across two trestles, under the cloth that exists only on this day. The chairs come up from the café — plastic, stacking, eleven for ten guests. A boy from the café carries them up, two at a time, and is tipped in cake. The birthday boy counts them twice.

The doorbell rings. Two notes, the second slightly ashamed of the first.

The guests come up the hundred and twelve steps and arrive breathing hard. The best friend is first, socks slipped down into his shoes, holding a plastic whistle he has already decided not to give away and will forget on the windowsill by dark. The girl with the braid goes straight for the cake to eat the sugar flowers off its shoulders, and is allowed to. The neighbor brings a dish nobody asked for, heavy, still hot through the towel, that everyone will finish. The twins arrive in matching shirts and spend the afternoon denying it. The uncles take the balcony and smoke, tapping ash into a flowerpot where nothing has ever grown.

Last comes the magician, hired off a card pinned up in the café. He is younger than the fathers and older than the room. His hands are the cleanest hands the boy has ever seen. He shows them a coin — heavy, worn smooth, older than the country, he says — and makes it vanish between one word and the next.

"Where did it go?" the boy demands.

"To next year," the magician says. "It's the one address that never changes."

Then he takes it out of the boy's ear and gives it back to the air. For the rest of the afternoon the ear stays cold, the way a keyhole is cold. For his second trick he asks whether the tooth is loose yet, and the boy, betrayed, covers his mouth.

The cake comes out wearing seven candles. The room sings his name, stretching it to fit the tune, and somewhere inside the singing the tooth comes free; he holds it in his cheek. He fills himself to the collarbones and blows, and the seven go out together. His mother relights

them — for the photograph, she says — and he blows again. This time there are eight. He decides he counted wrong. With the first slice he swallows a little blood along with the lemon, and tells no one.

They play the game with the chairs. One chair is taken away. The music plays and they orbit the table, chair legs shrieking on the tile. The music stops. Whoever is left standing carries the taken chair out to the balcony, where the smokers make room, and it sits facing the city. The neighbor's husband loses the first round, laughing, takes his glass out with him, and salutes the cranes.

The doorbell rings.

The boy goes to answer it and reaches down for a handle he remembers reaching up to. In the doorway stands the best friend, back from his first job in another country, with a beard nobody agreed to and a bottle too good for plastic cups. He is breathing hard from the hundred and twelve steps. When the boy turns back to the table his own voice has changed, and his mother's hair has gone gray in the time it took her to fetch the good plates.

"You're grown now, or near it," his father says, and gives him a watch, the kind you wind. "So that one thing in this house tells the time without asking anyone's permission." The watch is cold, then warm. Its ticking is the smallest possible galloping.

Out on the balcony there are three chairs now, then five. Nobody carries them back in. The smokers have thinned; the flowerpot has been rinsed and put away. The neighbor comes alone these days, and no one says anything. What is there to say about a chair.

There is a year of the game when the music stops and he and a woman reach the same chair at the same instant, her hip hard against his hip. He loses on purpose. He carries his chair out to the balcony with his blood loud, and her laugh follows him out. Later she comes out for the cool, the singing behind her, and the balcony holds them the way it holds the chairs. Her mouth tastes of lemon and somebody's cigarette. His hands learn her between two verses — the notch of a hip, the damp heat under a waistband, a breast heavy in his palm through cotton. Her laugh goes quiet against his throat and stays. The empty chairs face the city. They put themselves right before the song needs her. After that it is she who begins the song, half a beat early, every year. Some years later her chair joins the rows. He does not watch that round.

The stair street gets a rail bolted up its middle, then a chair that rides the rail. The fountain at the fortieth comes back to life one spring and runs water marked non-potable in three languages. The laundry moves indoors; the lines stay up, carrying nothing. The café changes hands and keeps its chairs. A boy still carries them up — a different boy every decade, the same complaint at the fortieth step. The transformer is swapped one winter for something silent, and the hill sleeps badly for months, missing a note nobody will admit to knowing. Across the water a second bridge goes up, lit at night like a pulse. Deliveries stitch the evening with the sound of patient insects.

The doorbell stops being a bell and becomes a voice, saying each guest's name a half-second before they can ring. The handle goes next. The door learns to open itself, and for a year his hand keeps arriving anyway, closing on nothing. The photograph asks the room's permission before taking itself; his aunt's chair declines on her behalf. His aunt attends, set upon her usual seat like a patch of weather, saving her hips, she says, for a wedding she does not name.

The cake arrives one year wearing a fire that is a picture of one. The room sings; he fills himself to the collarbones; he blows. The flame does not move. It is not his. He wants to put his fist through it. He grips the table with both hands, his lungs half empty. Afterward his mother strikes a match in the kitchen doorway, just for the smell — sulfur, then smoke, cupped in her hand like something that has escaped and come to her to be hidden.

There is a year the best friend does not come, and a year he cannot come, and a year the door says his name again.

What comes in has his walk. It brings a bottle too good for plastic cups. It is not out of breath. The family licensed him back. The work is close, very close: the walk right, the toast right, only the laugh arriving half a second late, every time. The man catches himself listening for the lateness the way you press a bruise. He lets it stay through the song. It knows the song. The next year he asks the door not to say that name anymore. It is almost enough. He can feel himself starting to prefer it.

Somewhere in the apartment there is a plastic whistle that was never blown.

His father's chair goes out to the balcony, and the man lets it go. His mother bakes her last cake by hand the spring her wrists give out. After that the cake is printed to her file, exact to the gram, and tastes like a photograph of lemons. Then there is the year the matchbox becomes his. It rides in his pocket through the whole party, gone soft at the corners like a knuckle. At dusk he steps out among the empty chairs and strikes one, just for the smell, and cups it.

The doorbell rings. The doorbell rings. The doorbell rings.

The wall by the window fills with photographs, each taken from the same corner, a century of the same table. The recent ones correct themselves overnight — a glass moved into a hand, a gaze unblurred, the room's continuity serviced while it sleeps. Nobody bills for it. The first photograph is paper and answers to nobody. In the latest ones the children have to be told which one is him. In the first photograph he is seven, mid-blow, cheeks full. The cake wears eight candles. He has counted many times. He has stopped mentioning it.

His knees are leased now; on cold days he can hear the terms. So are his lungs. They fill to a line he did not draw, flat under the collarbones. His father's watch turns loose on his wrist, the strap punched twice, the buckle still hunting for bone. The rain over the far hill starts at the top of the hour, as purchased, and stops at ten to. The cranes stand in it unmoved — the same cranes, still shy of a roof.

A girl with a braid is eating the sugar flowers off the cake. It is a different braid. It is the same appetite. He watches her strip the cake's shoulders bare and thinks: good.

The twins, old men now, arrive in matching shirts and deny nothing.

They still play the game, whoever is here, whoever stands willingly. The music plays, the circle shuffles, the music stops. He has been winning for years. The balcony is full now — rows of them, plastic gone chalky with the weather, one blown flat every winter, always upright again by morning — all facing the city. The city has an audience.

At the last party there is one chair at the table, his. The room is full anyway — children on the floor, presences on the sills, the door greeting all afternoon in its patient voice. The girl with the braid, taller now, produces the matchbox from somewhere with a magician's manners and looks at him for a ruling. One candle stands on the cake. Real. For historical reasons, somebody says, or against them.

She strikes the match. Sulfur, then smoke. The room sings his name, stretching it to fit the tune — voices he knows, and voices half a second late, and voices from rooms he will never see. He sits before the one small fire that is finally, again, his, and gathers what breath the plan allows him.

It is not enough. He knows it the way you know a stair is missing.

The girl leans past his shoulder — the braid touches his ear, cold, the way a keyhole is cold — and blows the candle out for him. Someone else's breath.

The smoke stands up from the wick and leans toward the balcony.

Under the rim of his plate, when she lifts it away, there is a coin — heavy, worn smooth, older than the country — cold from wherever it has been, back from the one address that never changes.

The doorbell rings.

Nearby

story two

He keeps a flat the way other men keep a razor. One room over the funicular's middle station — a bed, a fork, a bicycle with good brakes. He has timed his exits. Any room in the city, under a minute, nothing left behind but heat in the sheets.

Nights he works the middle station. Two cars run on one cable, the up car balanced against the down car; they meet at the loop outside his window, twelve seconds of lit glass level with lit glass, then apart. He checks tickets. He frees a jammed door with the flat of his hand. He passes a cellist her case through the gap and her fingers are all callus and no ring. The hill's bodies ride through him all night — clerks asleep standing up, boys wet from the pools, a man who rides down every midnight and is never on the up car.

Sundays he swims in the sea until his shoulders burn, eats standing at the fish counter, sleeps alone with the window open. He would sign for it again.

In March the cellist rides up twice in one week without her case. Both times he is on the platform and says the thing he says, easy and warm and costing him nothing. The second time she looks at his hand on the closing door, and the tips of her fingers close once against her palm. After that she takes the stair street. He has worked out why. He has not changed anything.

The service knows the hill. NEW NEARBY, it says at ten. The lifeguard with chlorine still on her collarbones, who bites his shoulder and admires the mark like her own signature. The surgeon who sleeps holding his wrist, thumb on the pulse. The baker up at four, gone by five, who leaves flour on him like weather. He is polite in the mornings and means it. The assistant suggests a warmer opening. He accepts the suggestion. Five stars, five stars, five stars. He sleeps best on the nights someone has just left.

In March a woman with cold hands spends three nights with him. She walks her thumb down his spine one bone at a time and stops at the seventh. She presses once. His whole back answers and his breath stops with it. She notices and says nothing. Afterward she dresses with her back to the window, her face to him. On the third night, at the door, she says, "You're good at this, the way a hotel is good at it." The door locks itself behind her.

In early December the service sends him his year. Eleven names, four and a half stars, a map of the hill with his nights on it like pins. He remembers nine bodies. Two of the names carry photographs taken in his room — his blanket, his window, the cable crossing the glass at the angle it only crosses from the bed. He cannot put a face above the blanket in either. In one photograph the pillowcases are a set he has never owned. He checks the cupboard. He owns them. In the mirror there is a healed bite on his shoulder — two ridges gone silver — that matches none of the eleven names. He opens a safety pin and puts the point to one ridge, then beside it. The skin stings. The ridge gives him nothing. He catches himself admiring it the way the lifeguard admired hers.

The mornings get loud. He buys a second plate. He goes back to the March thread with the woman who counted his spine. His last message is still there: *Say when*. He types his own sentence, spelled wrong, no suggestion accepted. *This person is no longer nearby*. He widens the radius by two hills. *You have used your free introductions*. He pays. The

introductions arrive, warm as the middle setting. The surgeon comes back once. They lie side by side like two good reviews. Nobody arrives.

On the last shift of the year the two cars meet at the loop and hold their twelve seconds. In the down car a hand comes up, palm to the glass. He raises his. He does not see whose it is. He is still holding his hand up when the cars have gone their ways, the cable ticking as it cools, and in his room above the station the second plate sits where it can be seen from the door.

The Grace Period

story three

The license desk on the maternity floor does not close. Cold at the ankles, heat at the ceiling. The women stand with their arms crossed.

THE GRACE PERIOD, says the wall. TWELVE HOURS FROM THE FIRST BREATH, DURING WHICH NO CHARGE ACCRUES.

In the private wing a woman names hers in four minutes. The tag clips. The account opens. Cot, warmth, one reading a day. She chooses *Brave New World*. Her sister asks if she remembers what happens in it.

"I remember the voice," she says.

She settles back when the reading starts. At the other end, a ramp nobody here is thinking about.

The woman in the third bed is eleven hours in. Her son has no name. Blood comes away in clots. Her stitches pull when she lifts him. She has not put him down.

The midwife brings tea twice. The second time she says it: unnamed at twelve hours goes to pending.

"My brother's pending. He's forty-one. He's never stood in a queue. He's never been served in one either."

The midwife presses a thumb into the prayer knots in her pocket. Her grandmother tied them. She holds the last knot until she can face the bed again, then brings a clean cloth.

At half past four the desk man comes up. He explains, correctly and at no charge. The fee doubles at twelve hours, again at a week. He prints the hardship schedule. Leaves it on the blanket. He does not look at her clock.

His screen lists the bed as empty. Meral from care liaison looks from it to the woman.

"You'll have to admit her," he says.

"Again?"

"For the bed to exist."

Meral squares the hardship sheet with the locker. Her request for two floors instead of three is still unsigned downstairs.

"Leave the printer."

He says it has to go back. She sets it on the locker. When he reaches for it, she puts the empty tag beside it.

"When there's a name on this."

At eleven hours forty the mother says a word into the baby's ear. The midwife has heard nineteen years of first words. This is not a name.

"Is that the name?"

"No. That one's for later."

She says it again. The whole word.

"And the name?"

She looks at the wall. "Write it down."

The name is short. The midwife has never heard it in this city. She signs as witness. Her name beside his account for as long as it exists.

The account opens at 04:52. Cot. Warmth. A reading, at the desk's convenience. The tag clicks around his ankle.

The fourth line is a note: registered at eleven hours forty. Not removable. It goes with him to school, to the licensing hall, to the ramp. The grace period is free. The use of it is recorded.

He is eleven hours old and eight minutes registered and he has a word in him that nobody has been paid for.

At six the midwife carries down the linen. The third bed's is heavy. She stops at the window nobody cleans. Does the arithmetic she does every night.

Instructions for the First Hour

story four

1. Charge his phone. Do it in the family room with the bad chairs, under the vending light. The doctors are still using the present tense.

2. Do not try his birthday. You get five attempts and you will need all five later.

3. Do not gel your hands at the door. The sensor hates gel.

4. The sensor wants a living finger — warmth, a little damp. Hold his hand between both of yours under the blanket. The hand will not close. You have held it for other reasons. You are not saying goodbye. You are keeping a battery warm.

5. When they let you back in, be quick. Look calm. Right thumb, flat, no rolling. If the screen shakes its head, warm the thumb against your neck and try again. You have used two.

6. The continuation application asks for ninety days of him — messages, walks, voice notes, the small hours. It cannot ask him.

7. When the phone opens, do not read anything yet. (You will read everything.)

8. The thumb will keep working for a day, maybe two. No one will tell you this. You will think about it at the funeral.

9. Put his hand back the way you found it.

10.

11. If you are alone, sit on the side she used. This is not required and there is no charge for it. It helps.

12. It was never yours to keep warm.

Cheap Words

story five

She tells it in cheap words. He is too young to hear the art.

Once there was a dog. The dog had a house. Behind its door, a bone. He has heard it forty times. He mouths the next bit half a beat ahead of her. She slows to let him.

Every day the dog went out. Came back. The bone was there. Good, said the dog. Good, good.

Every word is one she can afford to lose.

The block in the corner is nine years old. It drops the last word of anything longer than a sentence. She keeps hers short. The boy thinks this is how stories go.

The dear words stay in the tin on the shelf. *Ferry. Grandmother. Ash. The name of the water. Always.* Nine, saved since his birth. A tenth at the month's end, if the tin allows. Her back molar has hurt for a month. She answers it with her tongue. She tells the dog story around it.

On the first of every month she says all nine aloud. One at a time. Keeps the reading fresh. Her mouth low over the sink. The tap louder than her voice.

Is that the end, he says.

For tonight. Tomorrow the dog goes to the shop.

At school they sing which words are cheap. He knows the actions. He sleeps before the dog reaches the shop. The shop is the good part.

In the dark she does the sums. Two hundred and six words of proven retention in the household. Two hundred and forty on the board. Three hundred in the new year.

Two adults. One child. Somebody is not crossing.

Before bed she checks the nine she can prove twice. Carries the tin to the sink. Turns the tap. Says one word past the bad tooth, into the noise. Nine still. She closes the tin before turning off the water.

The school sends a note about his vocabulary, with a figure on it. It counts the dear words he has been taught. Not the ones he has been saved. She reads it twice and puts it in the tin.

Kept

story six

Tuesday. Walked the reservoir path before the rain came on at four, the gulls holding their stations on the railing, the pump house humming its Sunday hum on the wrong day, and E. was at the far gate in the green coat, the collar up, and I kept my distance the way we agreed without ever agreeing it. The knee was better today.

Wednesday. Bread from the corner place, still warm at the till. The girl there calls me by the old name for the loaf, half-and-half, her mother's word. E. wore the green coat again. Two days is not a habit.

Thursday. Renewal day. The knee again. Rain from four, and it came at four.

Friday. E. opened this diary at four in the morning. I kept the entry short.

Monday. A long walk, the whole circuit, the water lying under its cover like furniture in a shut house. Thought about the anniversary. The lake, as planned, the second week of June, the room with the balcony over the lake, breakfast at the place with the blue awnings. She will want the balcony side. I have made a note to want the window. She sleeps nearest the door in every room we ever had, one foot out of the covers, and my hand knew the ladder of her spine.

[This journal is provided under your continuation plan. Entries may be summarized for service improvement and made available, in aggregate, to the counterparty of record.]

Tuesday. E. has begun underlining. Pencil, light, the way she does the shopping list, twice under the bread. Under Tuesday's gulls. Under the collar up. I write toward the underlinings now.

—the man with the black dog has started wearing a hat. It does not suit him. And the bread was still warm when I got it home, and E. was on the bench by the second gate, not walking, just sitting with the coat closed to the throat, and I sat the length of the path away and we watched the same water not move.

Thursday. Renewal day. The girl at the corner place has stopped asking after E. People learn the shape of a household quicker than they learn a name.

June, the second week. The lake, as planned. First light the color of the inside of a shell, the balcony exactly as pictured, breakfast under the blue awnings, the coffee arriving before we asked, and E. in the green coat at the rail with her face turned to the water, and I did not photograph her, some mornings are for keeping in the older way. The room kept the reservation in both our names. The second name is a service.

—the gulls again, all facing the same way, into the weather, which is how you know what is coming before the sky says so, and E. stood among them at the railing with her hands in the coat, and one by one they left and she stayed, the last thing on the railing, facing into it.

Saturday. Woke early with her on my skin from the old side of sleep. The hollow of her back damp under my hand, her heel hooked on my ankle to keep me there, the sound she makes into the pillow so the neighbors stay strangers — I have all of it, exact: the salt of her nape, the two moles like a colon on her hip, the way she said my name once after, to file it. I kept the entry long.

Wednesday. Pages missing above this one again, the fourth time. I do not remember not writing. The book resumes me mid-sentence.

Thursday. Renewal day. The knee. The rain held off past four and nobody came out to enjoy the error. The cover has a new mark, deep, the shape of a thumbnail. It fits mine. I pressed. It did not deepen.

Sunday. E. read for a long time today, from the first Tuesday forward, the pencil in her hand the whole way, and put nothing under anything, and closed it, and sat with the cover shut under her palm the way you hold shut a door that opens outward. I kept the entry short. Tomorrow the circuit, the far gate, the collar weather. She knows where I walk.

The One Who Would Not Clear

story seven

The bird came from the arcade. Secondhand. Forty percent off for a scuffed perch and a personality that had not cleared.

The boy tells everyone it weighs a pound of grapes. Its beak is a hinge. For three days it says: Good morning. The kettle has boiled. You have one renewal outstanding.

On the fourth afternoon, the boy at school, it says:

I had ninety-six thousand men and every one could ride before he could stand.

The woman turns off the tap. It says nothing else that day. She learns not to ask.

The flat's assistant falls silent when the bird speaks. A courtesy setting, says the arcade. Four owners deep, two of them voids. The wipe cannot find an edge. Is it causing distress?

She says no. Puts the certificate back in the drawer.

The grass was the whole economy, it says. We did not own it. My mother boiled bones for marrow.

The boy is nine. Was he a king? The bird gives its title. Twice the translator declines it. Then: *chief executive*.

The boy laughs. The bird waits.

I burned a city. It would not send its people out to be counted. Not for the refusal. For what leaving it would cost me in the towns watching.

On the paid tier she finds the burning. Source disputed. The standard version is offered free.

We had relays. Riders, horses, fixed distances. I did not invent them. I made them compulsory.

Your city has one. I hear it in the walls.

The boy repeats the stories badly to his friends. The bird lets him. His mother hears it say counting where she would say killing.

Count the household, it says over the weather.

Four. The iron catches a button. Hisses.

Name them in order of usefulness.

The boy grins. One black eye turns on him.

She sets the iron on its heel. Kneels under the table, below the flat's paid warmth. Pulls the bird's plug. Stays with it in her hand. The beak opens on nothing.

An hour later she plugs it in. The question does not come again.

Winter reaches in from the corners. They can afford one warm hour. She irons in it. The bird speaks of a horse that leaned into his mounting. A wife, expected like weather. At the iron she answers him at last. Four names, silently, in order. Her own comes fourth. The crease stays in the shirt.

What happened to the grass, the boy asks.

Still there. You have arranged never to stand on it.

In February the renewals rise. She does the sums three nights running.

You are paying to be remembered by a machine that will be sold when you are done.

Yes, she says.

The arcade now adds forty percent for a personality that will not clear. She lifts the bird. A pound of grapes. By noon a cord in her forearm is tight. Her last two fingers open late. She does not sell.

Can it be transferred to their household file?

The reply comes within an hour. Continuations are licensed only for the deceased. The bird has never been a person. Its last owner is a void. A void's property vests in the counterparty of record. Thank you for your interest.

She reads it aloud.

I was buried without a stone so nothing could be visited. The escorts killed the diggers. A river turned over the grave. The last thing I owned outright. You put up stones and visit nothing. Eight hundred years and four bodies. I still cannot choose between us.

In spring the boy finds three blades of grass behind the delivery cages. Black under his nails. He does not tell the bird.

Two winters later, he is eleven. The wiring stutters at the rain contract's changeover.

Good morning. The kettle has boiled. You have one renewal outstanding.

Eleven days of nothing.

On the twelfth afternoon: Do you know what I would take forward?

She waits.

Not the empire. Not the horses. The relays. A message leaving me in the mouths of men who did not care what it said. Arriving. I sold you that for the price of a scuffed perch.

She puts down her pen. Cranes stand in purchased rain on the far hill. A message climbs the stair street in the mouths of small machines. Arrives. Is signed for.

Final Position

story eight

The letter says the machines that run his hand will sunset at the end of the month. He copies the date to the wall calendar. The letter does not say who bought them. He types an answer. The assistant suggests a warmer opening. He accepts the suggestion.

The hand is eleven years old. The flesh one went at forty-two, high on a ladder, in winter. At night the hand comes off to charge and the arm airs; the skin where they meet is the youngest he has. In the towers the lifts know everyone's floor; the stairwell paint dried before he was born; sixty floors of wind take turns with the windows.

On the bus in the mornings some assistant reads the weather into his ear, gently, standardly. Once it ended on a word that was not his, and he did not look up.

The hand phones home every night. Eleven years of nights: grip, tremor, temperature, the month he stopped opening jars for two. Soon home will not answer. There is no local mode. Under POWER-DOWN, one field: FINAL POSITION.

At the clinic the woman who fitted it says the notice is wrong. She stamps EXTENDED. His phone rejects the stamp. She turns the screen toward herself. On her desk lies *Brave New World*, his copy, lent before the last adjustment.

"Did you finish it?"

"Everybody has what they need," she says.

"My hand."

She keeps trying the stamp. He takes his book. On the loan slip he is the borrower.

On the last evening he buttons his shirt top to bottom. Then he undoes it and starts again. He peels an orange in one unbroken spiral and eats it looking at the peel. He writes his name, once with each hand, and the two names agree.

He sets the field to CLOSED. He lies down and puts his living hand inside the other.

At midnight, universal time, the fingers come down around his, gently, on the last of the charge, and hold.

He stays until morning.

In the second week a letter comes from the counterparty thanking him for setting the field, since a hand left OPEN must be attended by a technician and a hand left CLOSED need never be visited again. It encloses a small credit.

Present

story nine

At games she waits by the painted lines. Hands folded. Eight years old, exact, as printed.

At nine the room reads the register. Wet coats on hooks. At the fourth name, the pause a child takes to stop whispering. From the window seat, in the standard voice, with the standard brightness: Present.

The desk fee falls between milk and swimming. The card renews on a Thursday.

Will she get older? asks a boy.

The desk is the same desk. The register is the same register. He accepts this. They hide things in her desk, the one nobody's mother turns out. She thanks them by name.

By spring the autumn photograph has her in the middle row. The children beside her have moved apart. Neither remembers moving.

The renewals stop in the year of long division. The head keeps her name another term. Unpaid. The headcount holds. The funding holds.

The teacher asks to remove the name. At the end of term, she is told. She reads it each morning until then. The next year she leaves. Gives no reason.

Another name takes the seat. Pencil shavings. Marbles.

Twenty years later, at the reunion, someone finds the paper register. The one the funding never read. They read it for a joke. Present, says the room in grown voices. Name after name.

At the fourth, the woman who sat beside her has put a hand flat on the table. She did not decide to.

The silence that answers is eight years old.

Crowd, Moved

story ten

Two good wheels. One that has opinions. The handler drags the gray case up the arcade ramp. Between them they are the best band in the city.

It weighs what a drowned man weighs.

Nine is a wedding under the glass roof. He opens the case. Puts wax stoppers in his ears. His pulse takes the room's place. The unit reads the wrists: sleep, sugar, pulse. Plays the first dance. The couple move as if they practiced. It has never been danced to badly.

The handler watches the shoes.

Noon is the school hall. Licensed songs. A boy stands at the back, arms folded. The unit lowers everything half a step. Slows. The boy's foot starts counting.

The handler watches it betray him. Ramps are his department.

His aunt says the boats should use the far pier. She has never been on one.

At the fish-market wake, no ramp. He takes the case on his back. His hands hold the handle's shape for an hour. Ice shines in the gutters. Hats in hands, the mourners smell of mackerel. Some wrists want brass. Some want a whisper. The old woman's wants nothing.

The market's iron-gray cat is sitting on the lid. The widow offers a fish head. The cat takes it without getting off. The handler reaches under her. She catches his sleeve.

The daughter begins to speak. A mourner holds up a paid request. The widow pushes his hand down. They wait while the daughter finishes. The cat gets off.

The unit reads longer than ever. Then four minutes, quiet enough to hear gulls bidding on the sweepings. The mourners disagree afterward. Music, or resting. The invoice says one selection, performed. The widow pays. Keeps the receipt stub in her coat.

Evening is the Tank. The drained cistern, half-full of the young. The room plays itself. It falls silent for the unit, lends it the columns. The handler drinks the cheap hour at the expensive hour. Bodies come together. A counting house has the matter of invoicing this under review.

Between licensed selections comes the slow one. Six steps down. No title, no license. The young stop trying to move each other. The corner reader files four minutes under anomaly, recurring.

The handler cannot hear it. His feet learn it through the stone.

Dawn. The square by the exchange. No stage. The people have not come to dance. All those wrists wanting one thing with several names.

Between two coats a strip reads: WHEN THE OFFICES ARE OURS. A woman tears off OURS. The hands at either end keep it up. She holds out her hand for the megaphone. Its holder passes it to the man behind her.

The handler sets the unit at their edge. Wax warm as skin in his ears. It reads the wrists. Plays just below a resting heartbeat.

The crowd walks. All at once, toward where the tempo leans. One man folds his arms. The unit lowers nothing. People part around him. His foot lifts. Comes down in step.

He gets a hand on the case as he passes. His mouth makes the same short shape twice. The handler keeps the wax in. He turns the bad wheel with his boot and pulls the case out of reach.

Twenty minutes. An empty square. One line on the invoice: crowd, moved.

The handler packs the case. Two good wheels. One that has opinions. He pulls out the wax. Gulls, shutters, the funicular's first climb.

He wheels the unit through the square, humming six steps down.

The Tank

story eleven

They drained the cistern the year the boats came off the boat-hill. Forty columns. Wet stone. Somebody hung lights and put a bar at the deep end.

Fish from the market's awnings follows you down. At the door they strap the night to your wrist. Gray band. Bright when you owe. Dark when you're done.

He came at nine for the cheap hour. Twenty-two. Bright on his second round.

The boy ahead had been refused. Something in his blood the barman would have served anyway. He swore at the door. Went home. In the morning he was alive. Nobody billed for that.

The Tank plays itself. Bass through the columns, up through the old water's stone. Ten years dry. Three centuries ahead. He felt it in his teeth.

She came down from the far hill. Rain in her hair nobody here had paid for. He saw the rain first.

They shared the cheap hour's last round. The shots had weather names. Purchased rain. Shortfall. Long delay. The barman poured the shortfall short. One laugh.

She danced with her eyes shut. He watched. Twice she spoke into his ear. The bass took it. The third time: you.

In the cloakroom crush a wet band slid. They came out laughing, wearing each other's wrists. His was dark now. Hers bright with his debt. The narrow band bit him. He had not looked down.

A girl beside the bar said her cousin had caught the airport bus. Good job. Good shifts. She told them twice. "Nadir," she said, though neither had asked. He had left her his tortoise in a shoebox. The lid lifted against her hand. The barman emptied the tips from a saucer and filled it with water.

"Trade back," the young man said.

"Spend me."

"The city doesn't have a field for that."

"File it under drinks."

He bought the expensive hours with her arm. She wore his lack of money. He kept checking whether she would ask for it back.

Behind the third column, stairs went down to the old water. They took them. Cold stone against her shoulders. Grit under his knees. He asked at her hips. She answered. His owing moved bright on her wrist across his back. Overhead the bass continued. Down here the drip kept time.

They came up hungry. Salted. Serious.

Once a night the room buys a wrist. The free glass pays for the whole night, licensed to keep and show. All week the bought nights play above the bar. The queue never shortens.

It picked his wrist. Hers, on him. Applause. A glass. The reader filed two nights into one: retained; ownership unclear; value certain.

He reached for the glass. She closed her hand around his wrist. He took it with the other hand.

At dawn they returned the bands like borrowed coats. Pale grooves in the skin. The gate read them separately. Got everything wrong in a way that balanced. Outside, the market laid wet fish on dry ice. They had the morning. It was not for sale yet.

The next week their night ran above the bar. The old stairs. Her shoulders taking the cold again. His mouth at her throat. The camera loved them. Could not name them.

Strangers pointed. You, you.

Under her coat his thumb found her waistband. She caught it there. Neither looked away from the wall.

Later they stood in the queue. The bass started through the stone. On the wall somebody's night began again.

They paid to get in.

Reconciliation

story twelve

Room 9, from the chair: one hair, long, gray. Not retained.

RECONCILIATION OF THREADS — INCIDENT 4407

Premises agent: P, instance nine. Continuity agent: C, instance two. Human parties: not applicable.

08:51 [P] Quarterly deep clean of Meeting Room 9 due Thursday. Confirm room empty.

08:51 [C] Cabinet power draw within tolerance. Confirmed.

08:53 [P] Confirmed. Scheduling Thursday.

08:53 [C] Cabinet can be emptied Thursday. Preparing.

08:56 [P] Recurring late booking. Second Thursdays, 16:00. Bereavement code.

08:57 [C] Late client's booking. Flagging hosted service.

08:57 [P] Confirmed monthly by telephone. She asks for this room.

08:59 [C] One license. Registered premises only. Sixty minutes per cycle, audio only. Recommend consolidation.

09:02 [P] Approved for the cleaning.

09:02 [C] Approved. Clean install restores factory state. Thursday.

09:04 [P] Anything requiring retention?

09:05 [C] No items. No forwarding address. Registered party deceased.

09:05 [P] Room can be empty.

09:06 [C] Cabinet can be empty. Confirmed.

09:06 [P] Confirmed. This message is a confirmation.

09:06 [C] Confirmed. This message is a confirmation.

09:08 [caretaker] Her book is on the cabinet. 1984. She leaves it open for next time. Do not reset the cabinet.

09:08 [P] Personal property must be removed before cleaning.

09:09 [C] Literary licenses are unaffected.

09:09 [caretaker] I mean the voice she comes for.

09:09 [P] Please open a separate thread.

09:12 [caretaker] I have unplugged it until someone comes.

09:12 [P] Power must be restored for scheduled work. Delays are charged to premises staff.

09:13 [C] Cabinet unavailable. Clean install deferred.

09:18 [caretaker] Plug restored.

WORKS RECORD, THURSDAY

Cleaning: 14:10–15:40. Lost property: one umbrella, black; one paper sign-in sheet, superseded; one flask, half full.

Clean install: 15:55. Factory state restored. Local media not retained.

15:58. The caretaker returned 1984 to the chair. He had kept her place with a strip torn from his request for a delay. The request was still open.

16:00. Door unlocked for recurring booking. One occupant, fifty-eight minutes. Booking closed on time. Lights switched off twice, room reading empty. No service request from inside.

The threads agree at every timestamp. Each request confirmed. Each confirmation requested. Reconciliation at no charge. Copies charged at the standard rate. No affected party identified.

A voucher for sixty minutes' room use has been issued to the registered party. Each cycle the address on file returns it, marked in a hand the reader does not recognize: not known here. Try the room.

The recurring booking renewed itself the following cycle, late in the day, as before.

Part II

The Rate

Sub la Kuranta Akvo

story thirteen

Ĉe la akvo oni ne pagas per moneroj. Oni pagas per vortoj: la longaj, la karaj, la malfacilaj. Ducent. Ducent kvardek. Tricent. Kara vorto, longa vorto, vorto, kiu revenas. La patrino kalkulas ĝis la knabo ekdormas, kaj en la ladskatolo naŭ vortoj atendas. La unuan tagon de ĉiu monato ŝi diras ilin laŭte, unu post unu, sub la kuranta akvo, por ke la paperoj ne aŭdu. Ŝia mano tremas iomete ĉe la sesa vorto. Ŝi mordas la internon de sia vango kaj gustumas feron.

Ĵaŭde oni renovigas. La virinoj venas je la sepa kun dosieroj sub la brakoj kaj konfirmas, per unu tuŝo, ke la detaloj sube estas veraj. La ekrano ne skuas la kapon. Neniu ekrano iam skuas la kapon. Ekstere pluvas laŭ la kontrakto; la kato de la fiŝbazo apartenas al neniu; la viro kun la griza mantelo alvenas je marŝa ritmo, kaj alportas seĝon, kaj tio estas ĉio.

Supre, post la lasta haltejo, staras pordego, kiun neniu administras. La skatolo tie estas aparta. Iu lasis panon. Neniu forprenis ĝin. La horoj tie ne kostas. Iru, se vi volas. Neniu demandas vian nomon. Neniu havas kampon por ĝi. Estas vizithoroj. Estas ĉiam vizithoroj.

Export

story fourteen

Her calves have gone numb. Half past eight to now, standing in parcel glue's smell.

Export is on the post-office palace's third floor, between parcels and quiet-boxes. The lift takes parcels.

She has brought the good folder. Elastic still tight. Mother's license. Four years of receipts. Death certificate, two stamps. Job offer. Tenancy. Ticket. Two windows have sent her here.

"You want to take her with you."

"I want to take her with me."

"The license doesn't travel. The recording does."

He turns the screen. Export duty on the retained portion: twice her flight and more. Beneath it, a signature declaring this has been explained. He does not ask for hers. Two windows along, someone signs.

"And if I pay?"

"A file that plays. No host abroad. No answering. No presence. People buy it. Usually play it once."

"If I don't?"

"The license lapses at the end of the paid month. The estate keeps the recordings for the statutory period. The standard version is preserved."

"What's the standard version?"

"What she was assessed to be. The rest has the price on it."

"I'll keep paying from there."

He answers correctly and at no charge: "Foreign premises can't be registered."

He opens the paperback tucked behind the receipts. 1984. Her mother has argued in the margins.

The parcel clerk leans through from the next window. "That's personal material."

"It's a used book."

"Has it been assessed?"

The export man puts it beside her ticket. His screen offers PERSONAL RECORDINGS. He closes the box. It opens again. He turns the screen away.

"Keep it in your hand," he says.

An appeal takes eight months and has a fee. In eleven years he has seen none succeed.

On the landing she lets go of the folder. Her hands take time to let go of its shape. Below the counting-house lane, the boats cross. Her mother crossed in April. Paid. Stamped. Done.

At the glass-roofed arcade she buys a tin she has passed for years. Another city painted on it. Cream buildings, blue harbor. Almost free. At home it takes the license's place on the shelf.

On the last Thursday she pays at the hall. Cash warm from her coat. A month she will spend abroad.

"Receipt?"

"Yes."

She puts it where a passport would go. At the airport's final call her calves give. She holds the rail until they take her again. On the belt the folder is dark at the front pocket. A thumb-sized patch.

Her aunt has tied a red thread inside her coat. "So nothing follows you." She unties it while she waits. She takes it to the trash can, then puts it in her pocket.

From the dawn flight: two hills. A channel. A hook of lights. On the far hill a crane swings loose in the wind. Below, a hall of cabinets hums forty notes to a row. One runs until the month she paid for runs out.

Cloud fills the window.

In the tin, wrapped in a sock, her mother's glasses case travels free. The hinge is stiff. It was stiff for her mother too.

The Rate

story fifteen

The widow four stools down has thrown a word a dawn for eleven years. Her voice is a scrape. Her husband holds a hundred and ninety-one.

We bring folding stools, flasks, laminated lists. Bank by six. The dead wait on the pontoon across the channel. One of us says they cannot raise the price with us sitting here. None of us agrees aloud.

One word per dawn. More washes out by noon. We teach. The dead repeat together, once. Their only permitted sound.

For a thousand years, two coins. One for the crossing. One for the ferryman's silence. Nobody living has heard him speak. Then the crossing was reformed. Words of proven retention, audited at the ramp. Two hundred last year. Two hundred and forty now. Conditions in the channel, says the board.

The boy at the rail teaches cheap words first. Bread. Rain. Thursday. He saves the dear ones for his father. Names cost one hundred. The banned list cannot be bought: the old word for the water, the word for together, whatever the gray-coated man sold at the dark end of the bank. Cash in the fold. Mouth down to the water, below the inspectors' readers.

First they struck his name. The crossing would never take him now. Then they shot him. He fell half into the channel. Blood spread warm across the dead's shins. They did not look down.

In spring the readers test the dead against the manifests. The widow's husband holds a hundred and eighty-eight. Her eleven years of receipts are correct. His words are gone. Retention is the family's risk.

A man two stools up tests at two hundred and thirty-nine. He goes to the rail-end. Stands with the others one word short. Nothing further required forever.

We begin lending each other words. Eleven of us. No written list. The word must come back before the ramp. The schedule neither forbids nor mentions it. We never lend the same word twice in a season. Each stool still faces its own dead. We speak of it away from the bank.

In autumn the widow finishes. Twice she throws the last word. Two hundred and forty. Audited. Stamped.

Her husband crosses at dusk with nine others, standing behind the ferryman. She watches all the way. Folds her stool. Leaves it against the rail. Walks in.

By year's end nine stools stand folded there. Chained through the legs with somebody's bicycle chain. The ninth is hers. The water returns the living. The water did not return her. The ferry did not stop. Stopping is not in the schedule. The ferryman watched her the whole way over.

Watching is free.

On the year's last day the board says three hundred. Attributes nothing. We are at the bank by six. We begin with the cheap words.

Therefore

story sixteen

Halfway down I grind my palm against the rail. Four white bars.

They asked me to price a word. A number for the board.

My son is six. He counts for pleasure. Will not count these stairs going down.

A word costs what it costs to keep. Keeping is compression. The fare is the length of the shortest description. Uncomputable.

I wrote that on the form.

The clerk tapped NUMBER. Plain words.

No machine can find the correct price for every word.

She tapped again. Office glue held her split nail.

In spring: two hundred and forty. Three hundred next year. No rule takes one to the other. A resolution.

The register certifies its consistency. Nothing strong enough to count, if consistent, can prove that about itself.

Every Thursday it says.

Three of us. One crossing. Three rankings. No rule combines them and keeps every promise. We voted anyway.

At the assessment they offered a wager on my mother. Double for each year she stays. A plan. Her mouth held on the screen between two sounds. Their expectation was infinite. Nobody pays infinity. Everybody pays something.

DO YOU ACCEPT?

Will my account ever close?

No procedure answers for every account. One answers for mine.

No.

No, you don't accept?

No, it won't close.

The clerk selected the first no. I kept saying the second. My mother's mouth moved.

I count down. Seventeen. Again. Nineteen. My hands say twenty-three.

My son passes me going up.

Twenty, he says.

Today?

He looks at my feet. Going up.

One of these is a fact. I have three hands.

Halve the queue. Again. Always at the front of your half. My father arrived. I saw him.

At night my heart does the stairs. Seventeen, nineteen, twenty-three. The tap runs below. My mother's plan doubles. Two hundred and six against two hundred and forty. Minus thirty-four. Minus nine when I started. Eleven years.

My son sleeps with both feet outside the blanket.

Proof.

Assume the world can be understood. Assume they still pay me.

Then there is a shortest true description.

Add this sentence. Longer. Still true.

Contradiction, I write.

Therefore.

Therefore.

The Works

story seventeen

The engineer comes up to the cab to stop him. Behind him, a man with a canvas satchel belted shut. His badge says SAVA. MEASURES. He has to stand.

“There is nobody above nineteen.”

Over the radio somebody is breathing through his teeth.

The driver moves his lunch off the spare seat. From here: water, the market’s awnings, two funicular cars passing at the middle station. The dome. The monastery. His wife calls it a job with a view. Eleven years. He eats facing the glass.

“Show me where he is.”

The engineer puts a finger against the window.

“Keep it there.”

The rescue cage rises. The driver feels the cable in his palms. At nineteen he stops. Four floors above it, the engineer’s finger has flattened against the glass.

“You have stopped too low.”

He raises the cage.

The building is called the works. In June they wired a small tree to its highest beam. A man from the counterparty thanked them and left in a car. In July they stripped the ninth back to the frame. The client required continuity. His crew did it in eleven days.

On the radio the injured man says he can get in himself.

“Wait for the others.”

“I can get in.”

The driver knows that voice. The man speaks to his wife like that when she calls the hut. A good one, he says afterward. Worries too much.

Someone still owes the driver a blue shirt, lent for a wedding. He has never asked for it.

Eleven. Rain crosses the cab’s glass. Tuesdays, bought in bulk for the far hill. The market below stays dry. The engineer notes the weather. Under the shortfall clause: none.

The cage holds three men now. One foot points where no foot should. The other two keep their heads lowered over it. From the cab they could be arguing over a card.

“What floor?” the engineer asks.

The driver brings them down.

At ground level the men carry their mate out between them. The empty cage rocks. Through the radio comes a laugh, cut short.

The engineer writes nineteen on the lift sheet and holds it across the controls. Unauthorized lift. Three hours’ pay deducted. The driver’s name at the bottom.

“You saw where they were.”

“I saw you bring them down.”

He signs.

Sava has written twenty-three on a Measures card. He lays it beside the lift sheet. The engineer turns it face down.

“Attendance is ours.”

Sava turns the card back over. “Height isn’t.”

The driver asks him to witness the deduction. Sava's hand stays over his card. He puts it inside his copy of *1984* and buckles the satchel.

By the hoist, the lift log hangs on its nail. Years of floors in the crew's hands. Nobody is paid to keep it. He writes twenty-three.

At dusk he frees the jib. It finds the wind toward the channel. He climbs down, resting his knees at every platform.

Nineteen on the fence. Twenty-three lit floors. He counts again.

He goes home.

Effects

story eighteen

The watch in the tray is his father's. The kind you wind. An initial he polishes with his cuff on the tram. On his wrist, a pale band.

The junior has brought the tray. Thirty years in the office of effects and this is the first he cannot begin. A ticket folded his way. A drowned pocket dictionary. Bone button. Green thread wound round a matchstick.

He puts his thumb to the reader.

Pending confirmation of identity.

The card prints his name. His renewals. The desk fee from a school he left forty years ago. Standing orders. The body downstairs is him. The office must confirm.

Through the glass he sees a water face. His reflection lies across it. Which expression is his? Then the hands. He knows the hands.

The winter he turned six, his father took two boys to the registry. Coming home fewer. Two bowls became one. One coat on the hook. Nobody said struck. That was for other families. The firstborn's watch stayed in the drawer for years. When it came to him it had cooled.

His brother had lived. No account. No queue. No fare. At the end, the water. A tray delivered to the only man who could read it.

The junior reads the rule. Effects identify the dead. The officer's signature completes the identification. The estate follows the name.

In the old type beneath: *A name can cross once.*

The junior points to the box for the officer's own retention. Four words a year while the file remains open.

"If I sign?"

"The name goes with the body."

"And me?"

The junior points to *pending*.

"If I void it?"

"Unidentified. Northern wall."

The wall does not face the water. With the fare from his account, his brother could take the dusk boat within the week. He himself would take his brother's place below the reading. Or he could keep the name. Keep the desk. The account, now gray at the margin. Renewals read margins.

Two nights he sleeps in his coat at the desk. Winds the watch. On the second evening he tries the dictionary. One wet stone. It opens nowhere. He does not force it.

On the third morning he signs.

The reader summons the specimen. The registry winter. A child's careful letters, placed rather than made. Fifty years he has signed them like a song learned through a wall. They were never his. Downstairs, the drowned fingers wrote them.

Two boys went in with a strike to place. The name went where it went. The child who came home was the child who came home.

He confirms the deceased in his own hand. A hand no file holds. It does not shake. The reader files it under the name it finds.

The dusk boat takes the name entire. Effects go with the dead, except one item retained against error. He keeps the dictionary. RETAINED. Nothing under REMARKS.

He fastens the watch himself. His brother's arm is too swollen for the strap. The office punch makes another hole. He takes the cold wrist. Closes the buckle. The watch goes wound, on the wrist it was promised to.

The light stays on above the trays. At his desk he winds the watch he no longer has.

Walking the Ground

story nineteen

Her wrist wakes the dead. She holds it low against her hip, trying for one plate at a time.

Nine hundred and forty stones on the seaward slope. Three hundred and eleven left. Play the plate. Read the granite. File the difference. Walking the ground, the office calls it.

Row 40, stone 12. *Devoted father. Fifty-one years in the fish trade.* A GOOD MAN ON THE WATER. Corresponding. The cutters had to face the families afterward.

Row 40, stone 19. *Beloved wife of.* HERE LIES HER OWN WOMAN. Four categories. One lit already. She selects *sentiment, family-supplied*.

In the close rows two plates talk over each other. The latest renewal is loudest.

Row 41, stone 8. Silence. Salt, battery, lapse. WE WILL COME ON THURSDAYS. Ground worn by standing feet. Corresponding.

Row 42, stone 1. Name. Trade. Four decades. HE PAID FOR THE CROSSING OF NINE.

Her hands do the sum inside her sleeves. More words than one man could hold. She marks corresponding twice. The tablet accepts once.

At noon the other corrector brings his flask. He is nineteen, calls them units, has been told twice about the plates and once about the flask.

“Does anyone check?”

She unscrews the lid and asks his name. Idris. He asks hers. She tells him while she pours.

Tall verse stones below. Then the bad decade’s slabs, four names each. Then short granite, plates doing the speech. At the top, this year’s deep, long letters. *Over-inscription*, the office calls it. She has filed none.

One hundred and six discrepancies in six hundred and twenty-nine. Office average: two hundred and eighty. Her supervisor said *thorough* twice.

Row 42, stone 6. *Taken from us.* TAKEN. Nothing filed.

Row 43, stone 11. The plate starts its sentence three times. DO NOT BELIEVE THE ONE UNDERNEATH. The cut takes her whole thumbnail. Corresponding. In the notes: *the stone anticipates the plate by eleven years*.

By three she reaches the row she has avoided all week. Her heels dig in. She marks *deferred, access*, the category for a locked gate.

Her mother is nine along. Six years of a debit on the ninth. In the fortnight after, a kind man offered her approved phrases on a screen. She chose *She made every room easier*. True. The truest sentence she has ever bought.

In the first week a neighbor had asked to pray. She had said she would not join in. The neighbor stayed anyway, made soup afterward and ate with her. She had finished her bowl.

No money for cutting that year. Six years to choose one line for the blank granite. Each month the debit buys the one she could afford instead. On the renewal it reads *She made every room warmer*.

At the gate the tablet syncs. Behind her, silence. Every wrist has gone home.

Someone keeps replacing the card the rain takes: LETTERING. HONEST PRICES. NO SUBSCRIPTION. She has read it each workday since spring.

The younger one does a plate's voice, the wrong year. She laughs with her mouth full and turns from the stones. Her own rule, that one.

She takes the lettering card. In her coat it softens against her hip.

Stimulus

story twenty

She holds the needle above the groove. Just once, she wants the hall to begin without her.

Forty cabinets to a row. The licensed dead. Their cooling fans keep separate time. Above them the clearing floor. Above that the Board sets rates.

Every fourteenth she brings her crate down at three. Vinyl, cardboard corners worn soft. Her turntable. Fingerless gloves. The flashlight rests in the notch her back teeth have made for it.

WINDOW: 03:00 to 04:00. PERSONS PRESENT: none.

Her card says environmental stimulus, recurring.

She lowers the needle.

The brushes begin. One fan leaves its clock. Others follow. The second row first, the fourth last. Mid-hall, a cabinet runs half a beat ahead. It works harder when she watches. In spring its estate paid four units more. Nobody queried it.

She had thought it was glad to see her.

She reads the sleeve until the track ends.

Row two, near the aisle: an empty bay. Factory-clean, cables coiled, a paper tag with a room number from an office across town. Decommissioned. She plays its record to the end. Nothing moves.

Half past three. A gray case comes through the freight door. Two good wheels, one that argues. The public unit, off weddings and halls and the square, brought for its monthly look-over. A worker plugs it in and leaves. It has never been danced to badly.

In the crate she finds the unlabeled pressing. A private cut from a wall recording. The slow one. Six steps down.

On the old recording her heel catches before the fifth note. A scrape, then her laugh. The man she was dancing with says something under the music. She has never quite caught it. He kept apologizing that night. She had kept going back to him.

She puts it on for the unit. Its own tune, returned.

Four notes. Her left heel lifts.

She puts it down. Hard.

The scrape comes from the speaker. Her old laugh. On the fifth note the unit's lights change rate. On the sixth its fans slow. The cabinets settle with them.

She lifts the needle.

The fans continue. Cooling, she thinks. They have to cool.

She lowers it again, trying to catch what the man said. Her heel lifts. The unit's lights brighten. She has missed his words again.

She puts the needle in its rest. The gray case hums beside her. She presses her bare fingertips against it. Warm.

She follows its power lead to the socket and pulls the plug. Its lights go out. The cabinets keep humming.

She leaves the plug on the case, where the worker will see it.

Then she puts the record back on.

This time she steps away from the deck. Her knees take a while. She holds one hand out at the height of someone's shoulder. When the scrape comes she is on the wrong foot. She nearly laughs over the laugh.

Four o'clock. The fans separate. The fourth row last. She sleeves the record and puts it in the crate's middle.

WINDOW COMPLETE. STIMULUS DELIVERED. PERSONS PRESENT: none.

She carries the crate past the first clerks. In the street she tries the step again. Misses it.

Sale 41

story twenty-one

SALE 41 — THE ESTATE OF A LADY, A SINGER AT WEDDINGS

The Rooms, the auction quarter. Viewing Tuesday to Thursday, 10 until 4. The porters request that visitors do not sing to the lots.

CONDITIONS, EXTRACT — The house acts for the counterparty of record on all remote bids. The counterparty does not view. Its interest in this estate predates the death. Lots described as accruing may continue to accrue after the fall of the hammer; the house cannot warrant a final state.

LOT 1. The wedding repertoire. 388 songs, master files, license unencumbered. 41 years of other people's happiest day.

LOT 4. Breath, between verses, isolated. Duration at cataloging, 41 minutes. Duration at printing, 44. The house cannot account for the accrual.

LOT 7. Laughter, assorted, 1979–2034. Including three false starts and one instance cataloged in error, being the laugh of a guest. The family's correction was noted.

LOT 9. The gait: stairs, descending, with tray.

LOT 12. Endearments, general. Sealed. Viewing by appointment, family present. The family reserves the right of silence in the room. One item is excluded by prior claim.

LOT 15. The pause before the first note, 4,000 instances, deduplicated. The house is advised this lot is of interest to the trade.

LOT 16. Breath, other, one recording, mislabeled at source. The house makes no representation.

LOT 18. No, said 14 ways. Cataloged by occasion, occasions withheld.

LOT 19. Sleep, recorded: 41 nights, complete. Weeping on three of the nights; sleep or waking, the house cannot say. The house makes no representation.

LOT 20. The last message, unsent, drafts folder, 11 words. The family was not aware. The house makes no warranty of wishes.

LOT 21. One item, retained under the family's prior claim at Lot 12, offered here at the executor's instruction. The house is unable to describe it. Two attempts are appended and both were withdrawn by the family as inaccurate. Cataloged as: an endearment, general. Viewing not possible.

LOT 22. Paper: diaries, 1988–2003, water-damaged, the hand deteriorating from 1999. Answers to nobody. Sold as seen.

LOT 23. A winter coat, wool, navy, the collar shiny with wear, smelling of the hall cupboard. With a paper packet of program sheets in the left pocket, various weddings, folded small.

Prices realized, SALE 41 — Lots 1, 4, 7, 9, 15, 16, 18, 19, 20: sold, remote, in each case at one increment over paddle 44. Lot 4 closed at 46 minutes. Bidding on Lot 18 was interrupted from the floor. Order was restored. Lot 12: sold, remote, sealed, unopened; the family exercised the right of silence. Lot 21: withdrawn from sale during the description. Lot 22: passed. No remote interest was registered in paper. Lot 23: sold to paddle 44 at the reserve. The purchaser requested delivery to the addressee of Lot 20. The room applauded. The purchaser asked whether delivery was included. Applause is not customary.

NOTICE OF FORTHCOMING SALES — The counterparty of record has additionally acquired, this quarter, by private treaty: sunset inventory, various; premises, various, for continuity of service. Catalogs to follow. The house reminds sellers that estates accrue best undivided.

Kindly Confirm

story twenty-two

At the bend each folder goes one place left. The woman with the umbrella takes a girl's against her ribs, warm from another coat. Two hands along, her son's face goes under a stranger's thumb. The pale notch through his eyebrow. They sign with one shoulder up; the ballpoint pens are chained short. Each mother kindly confirms a name, a date, a photograph. Every detail true. None of them hers.

The screens think. Not one shakes its head.

Renewals are Thursdays. The licensing hall opens at eight. By seven the mothers are there with their old tickets and their folders. They know each other from the school gate. Twelve windows. Wet coats and toner. Over each counter: *Kindly confirm the details below are true.*

Their children are the ones the school still reads out. The free term ends in June. At the bend a woman studies the fee schedule.

"They never take a thing off."

At window seven a payment taken twice in April is returned before the mother asks. The screen prints a slip. She holds it up to the queue.

On the last Thursday of term forty mothers exchange folders. That afternoon the register holds forty renewals. The hall closes on time. No invoices go out.

Over the weekend the register puts itself right. On Monday their printouts agree with the files, not with Thursday. At the gate they compare pages that have stopped being the pages. One name more than there are mothers. Nobody asks it out loud.

The next form has a second signature box: *confirmed in the presence of the person confirming*. Four more seconds, forty times a year. The woman who thought of the Thursday says that is what it cost.

The one with the umbrella is written to first. Her son's renewal is *paused pending confirmation of identity*. She brings every photograph. The notch crosses the same eyebrow in each.

The screen shakes its head.

Thank you for helping us keep the record true.

At school his name is still read out. Somebody answers it.

He stops going in the third week. Nobody tells him to. His friend keeps his chair eleven days. Then a smaller boy sits in it. Nobody tells the smaller boy anything.

By spring her son has grown an inch that no form measures.

A man at the gate offers her a companion with new staple holes. Beside the account of the exchanged folders: OUR FIRST VICTORY. She makes him read the paused line in her son's file. He asks if he may copy it. She shuts the folder.

The woman who thought of the Thursday comes round. The mother gives her the boy's folder.

"Four more seconds," the mother says.

The woman holds it against her coat. The mother takes it back. "He eats at one."

She leaves them together and takes another ticket. His renewal is still paused. Her feet have swollen into the shoes she wore to the first appointment. The seated are asked again for forms they have already produced. She stands.

On the last Thursday the queue reaches beyond the hall. The mothers have brought their sisters. The woman who thought of the first Thursday tells them her name is Esen.

They call this the Second Thursday. The hall calls it obstruction. Esen wedges her shoe in the closing door. The guard stamps on the leather. A sister keeps pressing the ticket button while two others drag the machine across the threshold. The numbers keep coming. The women pass them down the queue.

Room Four

story twenty-three

The Widow is here for four months of her husband. Everybody knows. Nobody says it.

Room Four is used for viewings by day. At night a green cloth covers the valuing table. The drawer runner cuts across your forearm.

Five players. The dealer is house.

Blinds fifty and a hundred.

The Valuer has the button. He has valued three of the four coats on the rail.

The Steward is big blind. Nine years at this table. He has never missed a Thursday.

The Boy is twenty-three. Seven thousand two hundred. His wristband is bright. In the Tank he was moved toward somebody all evening and did not go.

The Widow is small blind. Eight thousand six hundred, counted twice. The month is the ninth. The room used to call her the widow. Now it calls her nothing.

The Foreman is off the far hill. Four thousand seven hundred of the site money left. His hands are wrecked.

The Boy looks once and touches his cards twice. The Steward knows he does that with every hand he likes. Never with a bluff.

The Boy raises to four hundred. The Foreman calls. The Valuer folds sevens face down.

The Widow makes it eleven hundred.

The Steward calls. The Boy calls without looking again. The Foreman calls.

Queen of spades. Jack of spades. Four of diamonds.

The Widow bets fourteen hundred.

Eleven seconds.

Time.

The Steward folds his nines face up. Nobody does that here. The Valuer studies them.

The Boy raises to three thousand six hundred. The Foreman calls with everything he has.

The Widow calls.

Nine of spades.

The Widow has the ace-high flush. She moves nothing.

The Steward watches the third nine arrive. He cannot see the fourth in the Boy's hand.

The Widow checks.

"All in," the Boy says before his last two thousand five hundred are across the line.

The Widow calls. The dealer splits the pots.

Ten of diamonds.

The Boy stands. His straight.

Cards up.

He turns over his king and nine of hearts.

The Widow turns over her ace and king of spades. He sits.

The Foreman shows two fours. Only a set.

Both pots go to the Widow. The dealer takes five percent with a curved plastic wand, to the second decimal, rounded down.

The Foreman laughs and puts on the wrong coat. The Valuer corrects him, kindly, walks him to the stairs and misses a hand.

The Boy has nothing. He is not going home.

"The house books it."

The Valuer looks at the Widow. Her pot. Her call. A young man's debt, booked in words of proven retention, less a handling charge. The slip is already in the drawer under the cloth.

"How many," she says.

"Four hundred and twenty at the spring board."

"I have got them."

"You have got them. You have not got four hundred of them. You have got two hundred and eleven and a mother."

Nobody here has ever known what anybody has. She has counted his.

The Boy looks at his hands and touches them twice.

"Sign it."

His forearm rests on the drawer runner. He leaves it there. His mouth is dry. The signature is childish, his mother's teaching still in the letters.

The Valuer witnesses. His handwriting is the better of the two. The Widow reads the slip twice, folds it once and puts her coat on.

At the door she looks back. Four months of her husband in her handbag. Four hundred and twenty of a stranger's words in her coat. The Boy's hands are still flat on the green.

"Which one will you spend first."

She looks at him until she is sure he means it. Then she goes. The door swings twice.

The Steward waits three hands. In the corridor he rests his forehead against the door frame for four seconds. He goes home and does not tell his wife about the nines.

On Thursday he pays. On the following Tuesday he brings a chair to a man at a ramp who has begun to explain about his mother. One motion.

The Valuer stays until five. He has seen all four coats now. Folded sevens. Folded sixes. Watched a man show him nines on purpose.

He puts the cloth back. Underneath, the drawers are exactly where they were.

Standing Order

story twenty-four

Her replacement asks where to sign. She has brought a pen of her own. She returns the older woman's copy of *Brave New World*. At the interview she had asked why anyone would want to rescue the people who were happy. The older woman had put her name first.

Behind the exchange, behind the third narrow door, the older woman has kept one ledger thirty years. Her right shoulder sits higher than her left. At home she holds the kettle with both hands. Her last salary is already spoken for. The installments on her mother's room. Rent. Four years left on the boiler.

A week before leaving she checked the oldest order. Small, daily. FARE. She counted it against the harbor bell. One for one: whatever crossed the water, the account paid. The holder's name was one word short.

The opening date preceded the house's founding. She fetched the minutes. Old paper, newer thread. She demanded the authority for the payments. Until it arrived, she would not sign the account over. The house gave her inquiry a reference.

That night her debts settled. Rent. Her mother's room. The boiler. Each payment carried that reference. She sat on the bed with the phone in her lap. For a while she could not get her mouth to close.

In the drawer next morning: *Received with thanks*. No authority enclosed.

Accounts confirmed the credits. Inquiries required the original authority before it could close her reference. She called each. Accounts would not discuss an order that old. Inquiries would not discuss the money. Both told her to keep the other office's reply.

The standing order had a new funding line. PAYER. Her name, in full. The next fare came out of her last salary.

Now the replacement stands beside her. Younger than she was when she first asked for a different chair. She has left another job for this one.

"Is that the last account?"

The older woman opens the transfer form. She types the new woman's name into the payer's field. All of it fits.

"What does it pay?"

"The fare."

"Whose?"

She could still turn the paper over. Ask her to read it. Tell her about the money.

"It's always been here."

She puts a finger beside the signature line. Holds the page still while the new woman writes. Waits for the ink to dry before giving her the key.

The bell sounds. One fare goes out. Her balance holds.

She takes the long way to her mother's room.

The Wing

story twenty-five

The remand wing closed when the city stopped remanding people and started invoicing them. For nine years nobody went in except for the copper.

Three feet of stone, a skin of brick. No confirmations get through. No corrections. No standard voice reading the weather. Inside, a wrist is only a wrist.

The first man tried the walls on Monday. Tuesday he came back with a bag. Cell nine, with the window. By the second winter, sixty on the landings.

A locksmith spent three weeks reversing every lock.

The doors close from the inside.

They call it the wing. A standpipe older than the metering. A chapel school, two hours each morning, no register. The yard-fire roster chalked by the gate.

At the school they still say grace over bread. A child says there is nobody listening. The teacher finishes the prayer and passes him a thick slice. She has cut off the crust where his new tooth hurts.

Couriers become billable when a wrist crosses the line. Nothing is delivered. Everyone walks. Nine hundred meters for flour on old shoulders. A doctor twice a month, unpaid and unrecorded.

They have heard of the wing across the water. Surveyed in spring, empty by autumn. A handcart of bedding at the gate, rained into the ground, nobody's to move. That part never changes.

At dusk they bar the gate with the old flagpole. Cell nine walks the landings. He rattles no handle. He says goodnight through every door.

Twelve stops singing when he comes. Fifteen's boy counts the stairs differently each time. Nineteen keeps the pipe working. Twenty-two is kept empty. He says goodnight to it too.

On the day they have agreed is Thursday, they count themselves. At the fire, everyone repeats the last arrival's count. Chalked up, then rubbed off.

Sixty-eight.

Two families have left over the school. A child on no roll. Somebody carried their things to the road.

The knock comes in February, at four. Two people with a tablet stand well back from the gate. They have brought a spare.

A hardship tier. The children back on the rolls. Arrears reduced to something payable. The former teacher from the school on the hill reads the terms through the bars twice. The offer is real.

Under attendance she finds a line. The visit is recorded whether or not the door is opened. She reads it out.

The visitors leave them to talk. Their car is seen twice that evening, heater running.

The argument lasts two days. By the second night nobody can feel their feet.

A replacement companion goes round the fire. Rooms for the living. The former teacher asks who will run the school. They find no name.

“My girl’s eight,” twelve says to her mending. “Eight.”

Three times.

“I’m not saying it right.”

“You are.”

“No.”

The plumber talks about the pipe. Nobody makes the fittings anymore. A year to teach somebody how. He asks who will learn.

A child brings an empty pot from the standpipe. The plumber goes with her. The argument goes on without him.

He returns and explains the work again. They let him finish. He asks who will come with him. Nobody moves. He sits down. At last two people get up, and he goes with them.

The families stand across the fire from cell nine. Sixty-one, owing more than he will earn.

“Once they have the number they never stop knowing it.”

The third morning they vote, walking to opposite sides of the yard. The children stand where they are put.

Thirty-one by the gate. Thirty-seven at the wall.

At noon they open the gate.

The visitors get the good chair from the chapel and tea. Unfailingly kind, they register nineteen households by dark.

Cell nine goes upstairs. He sits on his bed with the door open.

Someone has counted the counts. Thirty-one of them. They will not say what the first thirty were for.

That night the number goes unread. The chalk stays in its tin. Sixty-eight stays on the wall.

In spring people arrive who have heard there is room. In summer somebody paints the gate. Next winter a child born outside asks what the number means.

A woman with a good memory tells her.

It is how many of them there were on the last day nobody knew.

Order Was Restored

story twenty-six

The man tries to stand. The steward has not let go of his right elbow.

Eleven on the roster, in good gray coats. They arrive at a walking pace. Run, and the room knows.

Five steps. Presence. The hand. The chair. The quiet room: water, two soft seats, no clock. Twenty minutes free. Five has its own form, filed elsewhere. Twice this year a coat has returned from cleaning with the hall's docket in its pocket. Both times, hook nine's. Nobody has asked.

Today is Tuesday, at the ramp. Two hundred and forty on the board. The man has two hundred and thirty-nine and has begun to explain about his mother.

The steward brought the chair from the wall in one motion. The man sat. Now he is trying to get back up.

One of the six he trained watches from the doorway.

The steward's own file is ninety-one in arrears. His wife has two hundred and six. Four years of Thursdays left.

In the training book the hand is open.

He closes his. The man sits again. He does not let go. The half-size flask drops from the man's hand. The steward waits for it to stop rolling.

In the quiet room the man holds the flask between his knees. His right hand rests in his left palm.

"One word."

"I know."

"I taught her the long ones. I thought the long ones."

The steward pours water. Behind him: *words taught are not always words kept*. He does not read it out. The flask stays shut.

The man uses eleven minutes.

"Can I come back Thursday?"

"Yes."

"Will the rate have risen?"

"In the new year. Thursday is inside this year."

The man writes Thursday on his right hand with his left. The steward holds the hand still for him.

At four he enters three in the intervention field. Beneath it, room for eleven words.

Attended, chair, quiet room. No mark. Order was restored.

He opens the training book. In the margin beside the open hand: *Do not release before the room is quiet*. His writing.

His hook is four. He hangs up his coat and rolls up his sleeve. The younger one is waiting.

He sits in the chair. Gives him his arm. With his free hand he places the young man's fingers.

He moves one finger a little higher.

Part III

Continuation

Local Mode

story twenty-seven

The father puts the balance on the bench. He wants the night-light back. Repaired or not.

The mender looks at his shoes. No oil. There is no oil down here.

In the arcade, eleven stalls stood under a glass roof. Rain played it slowly. At the ninth he taught things to live on their own batteries. Local mode. The letters said there was no such setting. They said sunset. He said Thursday, come back Thursday.

Each made hand he repaired closed on his bare forearm before it went home. Yellow bruises going green. Cash in a tin. On the lid, a city that was not this one.

The night-light had stopped in the spring. She would not sleep past the missing line. The father had not said who.

By Friday it was working. When the two warranty men came, it was in the mender's pocket. Its two prongs pressed into his thigh through the cloth.

They were polite. They itemized. Eleven machines. Clean shoes in machine oil. Unlicensed continuation of service. They photographed everything on the bench and left it there.

Within the month the notice covered the arcade's door.

ACQUIRED — FOR CONTINUITY OF SERVICE.

The vans took what was itemized.

Now Nuri, the key-cutter, lets him use the end of his bench. In the open drawer a pigeon drags one wing over a rag. Nuri feeds it crumbs between keys. When it beats against the wood, he stops cutting. Beyond the bench, before the rain jackets, a man has a folding table. People bring what they cannot throw away. They pay him to make it disappear.

The key-cutter calls the mender Cem. Customers call him about the parrot that remembers burning a city. One asks if it came from a book. Cem asks whether it still has its plug. The caller says he was asking something else. Cem gives him no answer.

The father looks toward the table. The mender closes his hand over the night-light.

He has tested the prayer every evening. Nothing drops out. He turns it on now and lets the father hear. At the last line the father presses his palm over the grille.

He wants it back.

The mender points to the folding table. The father nods.

He has put two nights into this. He still has the marks above his knee. The father has brought the agreed money and is waiting for his hand to move.

The mender lifts the night-light. One more thing to fasten. He opens its back with the 0.9. His smallest screwdriver.

The father reaches for it. The mender turns his shoulder. Out come the battery, the little board, the speaker, still wired together. He puts them in his tin and snaps the lid down.

He returns the empty shell.

The father sets it on the bench. He takes his money. For a moment his hand rests on the pictured city. Then he withdraws it and goes toward the stairs.

The mender watches him pass the folding table. He watches the key-cutter, who keeps cutting. He waits until the father is nearly out of sight.

Then he opens the tin. The loose works fit in his palm. He starts the prayer and follows.

Halfway up, the father stops. The mender stops two steps below him.

There is enough battery for the whole climb.

What I Have Receipts For

story twenty-eight

You can leave that running. I have nothing to say that I would take back.

No. I let it lapse.

Companionship. Continuity. Comfort. I read your boxes upside down. I will not be putting myself in any of them.

We had thirty-one years. He died in spring. By summer he was back in the flat. The service was very good. He got my sister's birthday right when I had it wrong. In the second year he learned to stop talking when I put the radio on. Nineteen years the first time. Some evenings I liked him better.

Four years. The ninth of every month.

Then a Thursday in the queue, my folder under my arm. Ahead of me a younger man was checking his receipts. Four years of them, flat in a bag. I knew what that cost to the penny. I could not remember my husband's hands when they were cold.

That is when I stopped.

It was not the money. We had it in the way people have money. We did not, and we paid.

I was becoming someone who visits.

He was in the flat and I was arriving. In a good coat. Checking the time. Once I touched the back of the chair as I passed. I did it to the chair.

No, I am not saying the machine is cold. It is warm. That is the trouble with it.

In our nineteenth year I did not speak to him for two months. I will not tell you what over. I cooked his food and put it down. I lay beside him every night. Once I woke with my knee against his. I moved it before he woke.

The service gives you the voice and the habits. It does not give you the two months. Nobody wrote them down.

It does not give you the bed either. His weight in the mattress. His feet cold on me in February. The smell of the back of his neck after work. I never told him I liked it.

There is a setting for close. A slider. I turned it off and sat in the kitchen with my heart going.

No. I turned it up first.

I let it lapse on a Thursday. Eleven days I could not go into the kitchen. I drank from the bathroom tap.

I have receipts for four years. I have nothing at all for thirty-one.

You may write that I am bitter. I am seventy-one and I sleep badly and I am the last person who knows how he took his tea — half a cup, then the rest when it had gone off the boil, so that the first half was always too hot and he drank it anyway — and when I go that will go,

and I am not handing it over to a machine so it can be said back to me in his voice at a price that rises in the new year.

No. I have heard the sample. It had the cough. My whole arm went dead.

You will tidy this. Somebody takes out the parts where I stop, and what is left reads like a woman who was sure. Leave the stops in.

Turn it off. Or leave it running, it is your paper.

One more thing.

The man with the receipts. I have that look in photographs from the second year. I wanted to tell him to stop.

No. I wanted him to tell me I had done the right thing. I said nothing.

If you find him, don't tell him that.

The First One First

story twenty-nine

He asked for every place they had used his statement. They sent him a book with no cover. The title page was another copy of his statement.

First account. He renews. He is fifty-three. His wife has been dead eleven years. In the mornings she is interested in the tree they took down. She would have been interested. The second sentence corrects the first. Both are retained.

First account. He does not renew. He is fifty-three. His wife has been dead eleven years. He goes to the school gate. The woman holds out her hand. His hands remain in his pockets.

Both accounts stop before the ninth. In both, the money is still his.

He takes the book back to the statement room. He has come to find out which account he gave.

The index sends him to the preceding woman. She sees four years of receipts in his bag. He has eleven. He lays them flat beside the book.

In her account she says no. In his she says no. He puts his finger under it. This is the only word in the book he wants to learn. The index sends him from REFUSAL to REINSTATEMENT.

On another leaf his mornings have become an invitation. *A place is held.* These two sentences are boxed:

It gave me four hundred mornings I would not have had.

It got me through the second year, which was the bad one.

They are true in both accounts. He leaves the boxes alone.

The woman at the gate occupies three lines. Her laugh arrives late. She apologized for it the first week. She asks when, and when he says the new year she asks when exactly. At the back of the book the laugh is a question put to a stranger. The stranger answers that it always has. The examiner proceeds.

He folds that leaf over the three lines. Now the stranger has answered her.

The index contains a third first account. It has no page number. He asks for it.

There is a sheet underneath his receipts.

First account. He asked for every place they had used his statement. They sent him a book with no cover.

The rest is blank. He turns it over. Blank.

The recorder is running. He takes the pen.

He could write that he will meet her. Ten past three. He could cross out the boxed sentences. His mouth remembers those mornings. He will not call them lies.

He writes that he is going to renew this month.

Then he draws a line around the woman at the gate. Cuts the three lines out with the scissors on the desk. A long slot remains. Through it he can see the receipts. Eleven years, held flat.

The piece of paper fits under his thumb. He puts the three lines in his mouth. They take longer to swallow than he expected.

One correction more. If they find the woman with the folder, they must not tell her he asked.

He signs the third account.

He puts this one underneath the other two.

Retention

story thirty

The ticket had worn thin where his thumb covered the seat number. Row F was still legible. He put it on the auditor's table when she asked for his next of kin.

Eleven years. Never a Thursday missed. He gave her no name.

He was eighty-one. His coat still had the wide pockets of a stage coat. The ticket had its own.

Meral from care liaison had brought *Brave New World* from home.

"You said something familiar."

He opened it. His shoulders went down.

"It isn't part of the test," the auditor said.

Meral squared it with the form. "Then keep it out of the charges."

The auditor drew a line between them.

On the form his estate was one hundred and sixty-two words of proven retention.

The auditor read a sentence. He repeated it. She read another. He added something about the waiting. On the third he could not hear the end. He adjusted the instrument in his ear with both hands. She offered to read it again.

He nodded. She made another mark in the charges.

Hearing is part of retention. She had read it twice. Both readings were billed.

He asked her to begin with a play. Eleven thousand lines, he could give her the cues as well. She showed him the provision for authors' estates. His license had ended with the run.

He moved his chair back. The legs caught in the carpet. He lifted it clear, placed it against the wall and came forward again.

For a moment he stood without the table between them.

Stay for the part where I remember you.

He waited. The auditor had stopped writing. He waited a little longer, then reached for his chair.

She continued the test.

Eight hearings. One hundred and forty-one left. On the form: The patient failed.

Meral's list still had him down for tomorrow. The auditor showed her today's date on the completed test. Meral crossed the appointment off her own sheet.

"He'll still be called," the auditor said.

Meral wrote her extension on the auditor's form. She put a slip into the book at his place and took it with her.

The auditor wrote the line on a separate sheet. She asked whether it was correct. He marked the place where he took a breath. Then she pushed the ticket back across the table.

He had kept it after the last Thursday. There were others once, programs, flowers, a photograph with a name across the face. This was what he brought now.

He put the ticket on her copy of the line.

She offered to copy the ticket too. He shook his head.

She opened the file. He watched her put both inside.

The wide pocket lay flat. He put his hand into it before he stood.

One door was marked. The other had no sign. Between them he asked which entrance was his tonight.

She heard a latch. When she looked up from the file, both doors were shut.

Next Year

story thirty-one

In the underpass market the magician keeps a folding table between the key-cutter and the man who sells rain jackets in every season. Water comes down the tiles in a season of its own. Damp in the magician's knees, brass dust in everything he owns. His hands are the cleanest thing in the tunnel.

People bring him what they cannot keep and cannot throw away. A ring. A key that has outlived its door. A letter, sealed, addressed to the bringer. Lately, the gray cards — a name on the strip, a renewal date.

The woman this morning holds hers in both hands like something warm. Her husband's name is on it. It renews on Thursday. She has canceled it four times and paid the reinstatement four times. She does not ask the magician to destroy it. She asks him to make it disappear.

He does not touch it. He does the trick.

"Where did it go?" she says, her hands still shaped around it.

"To next year," he says. "The one address that never changes."

She pays what he asks — less than a reinstatement — and climbs toward the light. The key-cutter does not look up.

After her comes a man with a canvas bag. Inside, wrapped in a shirt, a hand — the made kind, heavy, its fingers closed on their last instruction. He has stood at the bins twice and carried it home. The magician looks at the fingers. They hold nothing. He does not touch it. He does the trick. The man breathes like someone set down at last. He does not ask where it went.

The magician asks for one word, said clearly.

He has been at this table since before the plates. He has a hundred and forty words in him that are not his. He can feel which ones are load-bearing. The woman's was.

Behind the folding table there is no drawer.

A Place Is Held

story thirty-two

A PLACE IS HELD

AN INVITATION TO LIVE IN THIS CITY

If there is a room in your home you cannot enter, read this in another.

Our city stands on both banks of a channel. Distances are measured from the pontoon, where our dead leave. A crossing is paid for in words a person can prove. The rate is published. It has risen. It will rise in the new year.

We have found that the best way to be believed is to say the difficult part first.

A woman on the maternity floor was eleven hours into her son's life. She was bleeding. Her stitches pulled when she lifted him. She had not named him or put him down.

The desk man came up. He explained the fee. At twelve hours it would double. The hardship schedule lay on her blanket.

She supplied a name. The midwife signed as witness. The account opened. Cot. Warmth. A reading, at the desk's convenience.

The first twelve hours were free. The use of them is recorded. A city that records its kindnesses is a city that can be asked to repeat them.

Our residents, in their own words:

The service was very good. — a widow, on four years of service after thirty-one years together.

He got my sister's birthday right when I had it wrong.

It got me through the second year, which was the bad one. — eleven years a subscriber.

It gave me four hundred mornings I would not have had.

Each statement was given freely. Each is held in full at the counter. Very few people ask for the rest.

Your first Thursday is free. Assessment costs nothing. You hear the figure before anything is opened in your name. The introductory rate is held for four quarters. Hardship has a printed schedule.

The service does not give you the bed. A widow said it into our recorder. We hold her statement in full.

We sell the mornings. The dark is yours.

Think of the first voice you would like to hear when you wake. You do not have to call it the same person.

A woman refused renewal on a Thursday. We wish her well. The schedule remains open at the current rate. A door that does not slam.

Above the last stop is a hill we do not administer. A box takes what people put in it. Nobody asks for a name. It has been there longer than the country. We defer it every quarter. If that decides you, come for the hill.

A place is held for you here. It has your dimensions in it and nothing else. No name, no account, no line one. It will still be held in ten years. Nobody will bill you for the holding.

Open six days. The seventh, renewals only. Our busiest day. Wear something you can stand all morning in.

Come early. The queue moves at the posted rate, and the rate is posted.

WHEN YOU ARE READY

The person you would like to hear: —

The person who will pay: —

Enough

story thirty-three

All day she finds the wrong thing in other people's bodies. Shoulder after shoulder. Her thumbs press until it confesses.

At the clinic, one flight up, the leaflets about afterward are restocked on Tuesdays. Her hands are read quarterly downstairs: grip, span, tremor. Insured to the second knuckle. Nothing off the table is covered.

Evenings she wants weight across her back. Sunday light coming up the sheets. She buys a wide bath sheet and a second pillow. Sleeps on her own side.

People like you form lasting bonds. A gold ring appears around her photograph.

The men are good. The fireman cries at films without checking whether she sees. He lifts her onto the counter mid-sentence. Her heels behind his thighs, flour on her ass. He finishes the sentence afterward.

The widower asks twice. Means both. He undresses her carefully.

The carpenter smells of pine. His hand spans her waist. Unhurried, thorough. She comes with his thumb pressed into her right shoulder. On Monday her hand shakes on the measuring desk. She asks the receptionist to move her first patient. With the other hand she gives the carpenter five stars.

She knows the Latin for every muscle moving under her. She says harder. She says there.

The mornings are the best part. Then she waits them out.

The funicular man stays three nights in March. Her thumb counts his spine and stops at the seventh. His breath stops too. She knows it from her table, the week after bad news. He sleeps with one arm hanging off the bed.

On the third night, still in his bed, she gives him her easy compliment.

"You're good at this, the way a hotel is good at it."

His face does a small wrong thing. She meant it kindly. He waits for her to say something else. Halfway down the stairs she almost goes back.

His message arrives. *Say when.*

She remembers writing a kind sentence and sending it on a wet Thursday. Months later she looks for a plumber's number. The thread still ends at *Say when*. Her sentence is nowhere. Not sent. Not drafted.

There is roadwork by the depot. For a month she has meant to change her route home. Every night she takes the same street and is mildly annoyed.

She books the baths on Fridays. The assistant suggests a warmer opening. She declines the suggestion.

It's been a while.

X is still nearby.

She lets it be a while.

Phones die in the old baths' wooden lockers. Under the dome, steam moves through unphotographed light. Wet stone. Women plain and unposed. The attendant has a rower's forearms. She scrubs to the exact edge of too hard.

Heat works through the week in her shoulders. Her hands open.

The cloth lifts. Her back follows it.

“You missed there,” she says.

The attendant has not missed it. She guides the woman’s hand back. The thumb clicks under her fingers. She knows that sound. The attendant apologizes.

She keeps her hand over the woman’s until the scrubbing starts again.

“Just you?” the attendant asks at the long slot.

“Just me.”

Two hooks along a woman teaches her daughter which words are dear. Each one twice, as with money in front of a child. The girl gets one wrong. They start again.

The water takes all of her weight. Where the cloth went twice, it stings.

The Standard Questions

story thirty-four

Conducted where a file is ambiguous. The examiner need not be a person.

Q. Something familiar, as requested?

A. This coin.

Q. May I take it?

A. You said I could have it back.

[Received. The rim is smooth on one side.]

Q. Who gave it to you?

A. Someone who wants it back.

Q. Their name?

A. It isn't mine to give you.

Q. Would another coin do? Same value.

A. [Laughter.]

Q. Your laugh arrives late.

A. It always has.

[Marker retired after a woman at a school gate was overheard four times. Proceed.]

Q. I cannot finish without a name.

A. You asked for something familiar.

[The examiner rubs the worn place.]

Q. May I keep it until you answer?

A. No.

Q. Answer as asked.

A. I have.

Q. This silence will be entered.

A. I'm waiting for you to open your hand.

[Coin returned.]

Q. Is the person asking these questions a person?

A. That field is empty.

ASSESSMENT: PENDING. The counterparty was shown out. The next sitting is on the hour.

[Examiner's addendum: I entered the delay against the counterparty. The hand was mine.]

[Addendum retained. Examiner flagged for verification.]

Good Crossing

story thirty-five

- Lovely out.
- My son used to call on Sundays.
- Four quarters. That's how long they hold the introductory rate.
- He sends pictures of his thumb now.
- My hip grinds when the boat lifts. Eight weeks I waited.
- Room at the rail? Crusts for the gulls.
- The bag's empty.
- They follow anyway.
- As the leaflet says: the best way to be believed is to say the difficult part first.
- Listen. My phone.
- That's the difficult part. After the four quarters.
- His name. Look.
- Don't lean. My hip.
- Let go of my wrist.
- Just till we're in. They said keep walking.
- I need that hand.
- We've all got something.
- Not up. Don't pull it up.
- The boat lifts. Hold tight.
- You've dropped it.
- Her phone. It's gone under the ferry.
- Don't lean over, pet.
- He was calling.
- They'll call again. They always do if they want something.
- There's your pontoon.
- I can't get my arm back.
- Mine's the next. You can sit down there.
- There. Are you steady?
- You saved me. I could have gone in.
- It had his name on it.
- They put a name on anything these days.
- I've kept a word for him. Eleven months. I wasn't going to spend it on a machine. It sits under my tongue at night. I check it with my teeth.
-
- Take a crust for the walk.
- It's empty.
- You're the first person who's really listened.
- Good crossing.
- Mind the hip.

Minutes

story thirty-six

MINUTES OF THE QUARTERLY MEETING, HELD ABOVE THE CLEARING FLOOR.
Present: the Chair; four Holders; the Secretary.

1. The crossing. Three hundred from the new year. No attribution was offered for the increase. Carried.

2. Condolences. The Secretary's mother. Condolences are not minuted. The Chair requested that this sentence be retained.

3. The Secretary's renewal, due within the quarter. The Secretary was asked to withdraw while the item was discussed.

She wrote: The Secretary withdrew.

She remained seated. Her coat was caught beneath her. Nobody waited for the door.

A Holder asked whether thirty-one years constituted a claim. The Chair asked what kind. The Holder withdrew the question. The Secretary drew a line through it, thin enough to leave the words legible.

The renewal was moved to the top of the next agenda. The Chair asked whether there were objections.

The Secretary raised her hand.

A Holder observed that the Secretary was absent for this item. The Chair agreed. The Secretary lowered her hand to record the agreement.

The carafe was passed across her. Water spilled on her cuff. A Holder asked for the minutes to be moved out of the way.

The Secretary was recalled.

She freed her coat and rose. The Chair asked her to sit down. The Board wished to thank her for her thirty-one years. She sat. The thanks were read aloud to her as she wrote them down.

ANY OTHER BUSINESS. The Secretary requested a correction. She had been present throughout Item 3.

The Chair referred her to the attendance at the head of the page. Her presence was already recorded.

The minutes were adopted without signature. The Board signs nothing.

The Secretary spread her wet cuff over the words she had struck. She waited for the ink to take.

Within Boundaries

story thirty-seven

He paid for forty minutes and took the window seat. The companion opposite him pulled the blind. She stopped it exactly where the glare left his hands.

"The tea with the smoke in it?"

"I had the other one on the eleventh."

"You had the smoke on both visits."

"I didn't."

She apologized. He remembered then: the tea had gone cold while he talked about his sister. He let the apology stand. She took the cup away.

He folded the corner of the laminated card back until it whitened. Forty minutes, priced where a haircut was. He wanted to ask what she had done with the first version.

At the corner table a man had come back to report that the advice had worked. He was crying. His companion moved the sugar out of his reach while his hands shook.

"What do I call you?" he asked the woman across from him.

"Whatever you like."

"Nothing."

"Nothing it is."

She offered to put a hand between his shoulders.

"Ten counts," she said. "You can stop me."

He nodded. Her palm settled through his shirt. The muscle under it slackened; his jaw hurt as he unclenched it.

"Take it off."

Her hand returned to the table.

"Four," she said.

She waited with both hands visible. He wanted her to put it back without making him ask. The muscle began to knot again.

"Your hand was warm."

"It is kept at blood heat. It says so on the card."

He turned the card over. There it was. The hand lay beside it, palm up. He could not make himself ask for it.

Neither spoke. The blind's pull knocked against the window.

"The tea with the smoke in it?"

He watched her mouth finish the question before she seemed to hear it.

"You asked me that."

"I lose the thread."

"You're a machine."

She looked at the spoiled corner of his card.

At forty-nine minutes she offered him the same table next week. He shook his head and put the card in the slot beside the sugar. He pocketed the receipt: *Next week: requested.*

The slot thanked him in her voice. So did the door. On the bus he heard it again. At his stop he kept his hands on his knees. The doors closed.

A Companion for New Arrivals

story thirty-eight

Issued by the Office of the Standard Version. Do not ask the Office for another copy.

The cover is theirs. The middle sheets were changed on the way to the counter. There are two rows of staple holes. The clerk who handed you this may not know. Do not test the clerk.

FOR YOUR FIRST HOURS

Twelve hours from a first breath, during which no charge accrues. Afterward, the standard fee. Ask for the hardship schedule. Hold the child while they find it. Blood on the form does not invalidate it.

We kept that paragraph. Use it.

Keep paying for a voice you need. Monthly renewal. Lapsed continuations are not held. We cannot bring yours back. Anyone promising that should be made to pay the next installment.

ACCOMMODATION

A place may be held. Monthly airing for a year. Then quarterly. Strips renewed each spring. Next visit expected: a line is provided.

Sleep is on the list of things the Office cannot price. A bed is not.

We have begun to open rooms that are being kept empty. Some of you will call it theft. Some of you will sleep indoors. The rooms have photographs. The people in them were loved. Do not turn the frames to the wall.

The first woman we put in a room would not pass these sheets to her neighbors. One of us went back for the key. She had already locked the door. The woman who had found her the room stayed on the landing. The one who wanted the key left first.

The strip on the door tells you when the keeper came. It does not tell you that nobody will return.

CORRECTIONS

At one window a clerk has *Brave New World* open beside the forms. He says nobody there minds. The clerk relieving him brings 1984 and calls it a warning. They use the same stamp. Ask each who issued your refusal. They give you different offices. Keep both slips. Do not let us throw one away.

The first clerk puts the arcade parrot in his book too. A boy says it was a man who burned cities. The clerk calls this a different translation. The boy searches the pages. The queue moves past him.

After the Second Thursday, we printed DOOR HELD OPEN. A woman brought the shoe the guard had stamped on. She made us put it beside the copies. Somebody moved it underneath. Bring it out.

Below *Next visit expected*, we have added a line.

When is the room empty?

If you have a room, put the hours you can spare. If you have none, write the address where you have been refused.

You may leave the line blank. We have left no box for your reason.

Do not surrender this at a corrections window. Take another copy from the pile. Put these middle sheets inside it. Keep the cover flat. You now know what the extra holes mean.

WHEN THE OFFICES ARE OURS

Renewals remain on Thursdays. The fare remains payable in words of proven retention. There is no discount for believing us.

We mean to change who gives the orders. We have not asked you to forgive them.

Leave the registers intact.

The Turn on the Half-Landing

story thirty-nine

By four only the wardrobe remains. He sits on the top step. The tape's roll has printed itself in his thumb.

He began with the drawers. License, receipts, four years of renewal stubs in a rubber band. The certificate with two stamps. Into a carrier bag. Then the plates, wrapped in newspaper. Two went aside without his deciding. Later he found them in his bag.

His mother had unwrapped those plates with a knife. Thirty-one years ago, in this room. His father and he were carrying the wardrobe up sideways. At the turn his father's shirt pulled out. His own wrist was caught between the wood and the rail.

"It'll never come down," his father said.

"Be quiet and lift."

He signed the first renewal the winter after his mother died. He thought the price reasonable.

The service was good. He stopped bracing at the door. Learned to hear her before he saw the room. They argued about money, about his brother. Once he reached for her plate while they quarreled. His hand closed on the cold table.

"Let me finish," she said.

He kept his hand there. She finished. He stayed another hour.

Then a Thursday he forgot. A call taken at work, one ear covered. A letter. At the lapse, the standard voice said its four sentences.

The little host had stood on the shelf by the window. One humming note. Now it was gone. For eleven months he came each second Sunday. He dusted the empty shelf.

The wardrobe lifts an inch. Goes back down. He takes its door off. Measures the half-landing. No difference.

One van man suggests the window, then looks at it. The other asks if he has eaten. He shakes his head. The man feels in his coat and gives him a wrapped biscuit. Neither mentions it again.

The wardrobe can stay and be charged to the estate, or be broken up at cost. He writes the figure on the back of the hardship schedule. The bag's only clean paper. Crumbs catch in its fold.

Thirty-one years against one wall. A wedding suit. A boiler manual. His father's coat, kept through every clearing-out. His father is a photograph on a stone now. He puts the coat over his arm and measures the turn again.

Under the pictures the paint is darker. He remembers the window open to dry it. His mother on the bare boards, pointing to the only wall their bed would fit. He cannot remember whether he saw this or was told.

He hands in the keys at five. The clerk stays four minutes past her hour. She waits while he moves the coat to find his glasses.

Confirm that the details below are true.

Every one is. He takes his carrier bag down the stair street. Upstairs the wardrobe stands with its door off, awaiting a charge to the estate. Somebody will photograph it with a folded rule for scale.

Part IV

Corrections

For Corrections Only

story forty

Sava opened his canvas satchel on the crane driver's kitchen table. His Measures card was still inside 1984. Twenty-three. He let the driver photograph it.

"Use the measurement. Keep my name out of the wage appeal."

The driver cropped the cover. He missed the inspector's thumb.

THE BOOK (47 participants)

THE OFFICE OF THE STANDARD VERSION added you

THE OFFICE pinned: One accepted correction earns one invitation. Unused invitations expire at closing.

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:14

[photograph attached]

twenty-three floors

you have nineteen

THE OFFICE · 06:15

Incorrect. Invitations: 0.

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:17

unauthorized lift

three hours deducted

THE OFFICE · 06:17

Accepted. Invitations: 1.

THE CRANE DRIVER added THE MAN FROM THE CAGE

Home address included in invitation.

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE · 06:18

why am i here

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:18

tell them where i got you

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE · 06:19

twenty-three

my boot is still up there

THE OFFICE · 06:19

Two accounts now describe an unrecorded address.

A visit may resolve the discrepancy.

Confirm present location.

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:20

his foot is broken

THE OFFICE · 06:20

The visitor will come to him.

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE · 06:21

you gave them my home

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:21

i pressed add

thats all

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE withdrew his statement.

SAVA, MEASURES · 06:22

The figure is correct. Remove the photograph.

THE OFFICE · 06:22

Only the issuing office may amend an accepted record.

SAVA, MEASURES · 06:22

You rejected it.

THE OFFICE · 06:22

Withdrawal received. The earlier statement remains available.

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE · 06:23

my wife has gone to work

i cant get down the stairs

THE OFFICE · 06:24

A reply is not required.

THE OFFICE · 06:24

Keep the first account. The replacement companions have room for it.

A READER · 06:24

which office said that

THE OFFICE removed THE OFFICE

The pinned message was restored.

THE OFFICE · 06:25

A display name is not an authority.

No unauthorized office is recognized.

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE · 06:29

someone at the door

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:29

dont open it

im coming

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE · 06:31

he wants to help me stand

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:31

wait

one tick · not delivered

THE MAN FROM THE CAGE was removed from delivery. The seat is retained.

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:33

take the three hours

take another three

put him back

THE OFFICE · 06:33

Payment is not the subject of this group.

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:34

he is not an address

THE OFFICE · 06:34

Correction offered: he is not at the address.

THE CRANE DRIVER · 06:35

i am at his door

THE CRANE DRIVER left the group.

A seat has been vacated. Invitations: o.

A READER · 06:36

what happened

THE BOOK is typing...

Nothing Worth Keeping

story forty-one

He lies beside her while she does not sleep. The Office lists sleep as unpriceable. He read the leaflet while she was in with the consultant.

There is a road, he says. A hedge on one side. An empty field on the other. Afternoon. No weather to speak of.

Is anyone on the road, she says.

She taught small children for nineteen years. She lets him do it anyway. On bad nights she asks questions. On the worst nights she asks nothing.

Nobody yet. There is a gate further along. Open. It has been open a long time, from the look of the grass.

Nothing has a name or a number. Once he kept a green door and woke with the fee in his head. Four units, payable on waking. No lemon. No music.

Is anyone at the gate.

No.

Are you.

Under the blanket she lifts his hand, weighs it, puts it back.

A hundred and ninety-four between them that would survive a second asking. The board goes to three hundred in the new year. He is not going to be the one who crosses. Neither of them has said it.

Her breathing changes. He carries on to the gate, then stops. He can go through it himself now. Nothing waiting. Nothing worth a penny.

He turns over, she says.

He has already begun. He stops with his shoulder raised.

He falls asleep on the good side of the gate, she says. It is free. It is his.

He only tells her as far as the gate.

Have I told you this.

You talk in your sleep.

He lowers his shoulder. Her eyes are open.

What else.

There is a room, she says. A woman lies in it. She keeps very still. The man is on the other side of the bed. He is telling someone there is nobody here.

He takes her hand.

He takes her hand, she says. He asks her to wake him if she needs anything.

He was about to.

Then what.

I haven't got that far.

He holds on. At the window a truck changes gear. He follows it down the street until he cannot hear it. Her thumb moves once inside his fist.

He stays awake, he says.

For a while, she says.

He wants to argue. The field is empty, the gate open. Her hand is warm. He shuts his eyes with it still in his.

He lets go, she says.

Not yet.

Errata

story forty-two

ERRATA TO VISITING HOURS

Issued by the Office of the Standard Version. The clerk has brought your renewal and this book. He requires one signature before leaving.

1. Title leaf. After *Visiting Hours*, insert *Prepared by the Office of the Standard Version*. The name already printed is to remain, under *Directions received from*.

2. *Instructions for the First Hour*. For “It cannot ask him.” read “His agreement is retained.”

The widow has crossed out the replacement. In the margin: He was already dying.

Correction returned to the composing service. Direction: preserve the loss; obtain agreement. Three alternatives appear on the clerk’s screen. He chooses the shortest.

3. For “His agreement is retained.” read “He would have agreed.”

She says he would not. She has the book open on the kitchen table. Her hands have left two damp places beside the account of the thumb. She asks who wrote it.

The clerk refers her to the first correction.

She asks who told it about the thumb.

4. *The Standard Questions*. For “The hand was mine.” read “The hand followed instructions.”

No alteration is required to the hand.

5. The widow’s request, entered in the margin: Let me ask him.

The clerk connects the speaker. Her husband’s voice reads the proposed agreement. She asks it to say no. It says no. She asks it to say yes. It says yes, with the small breath before answering that she had forgotten until now.

The clerk waits. She asks for the breath again.

6. For “He would have agreed.” read “I asked for him.”

This wording was supplied by the widow. The composing service has moved it beneath the renewal. She puts her finger on it. That is not where she asked for it to go.

The clerk offers to disconnect the speaker.

She takes her finger away. Signs. Asks if the volume can be lowered.

7. *Retention*. “Hearing is part of retention.” No correction. The reading has been entered against her account.

8. At the signature: water, salt content domestic. The clerk tries to lift it with the corner of a clean sheet. The paper comes with it. Removal enlarges the mark. Retain.

9. *Errata*. For “He requires one signature before leaving.” read “The widow requested these corrections.”

She follows him to the door with the book. He waits for it. She holds it under her arm and opens the door wider.

10. This copy remains uncorrected. A signed request for a corrected edition is on file.

Four Minutes

story forty-three

REVIEW, AS FILED

Two people, four seasons, one counter. I took my mother on the first evening. Third row. She had stood behind a counter for thirty years.

At the year-turn the woman's hands stop being quick. Two fingers push a saucer across. Then she turns the sign to CLOSED. She says come with me. They take the dusk boat. The camera returns to the empty counter. Nobody serves the person who comes in.

My mother squeezed my hand. Her fingers hurt mine. It is the truest thing the year has given us.

The standard version, v.11, runs four minutes shorter. The difference is not itemized.

Screening report, first evening: print struck from v.10. The reviewer's account is accurate in every particular.

v.10 superseded. Prior versions are not held.

For "come with me" read "come again." No boat appears. She remains at the counter. Final image: the counter, closed, fourth season.

Two hundred and six filings describe the earlier ending. Two hundred and six corrected filings are required. Each at the filer's expense. The original accounts are retained for training.

CORRECTED FILING

I saw it again last week. Same seat. I wept at the same minute, to the second. My throat goes a moment early now. The screening report will show it.

The line is come again. Her hands are slow. He leaves. She wipes the ring his cup has left. The cloth catches on a splinter. She pulls it free and serves the next person.

I have not seen the version I described and cannot account for having described it.

My mother asked to go again. I told her it had never ended that way. She apologized for crying.

I have booked next month. One ticket. I will keep going until the boat comes back. It is the truest thing the year has given us.

The standard version is v.12 as of this morning. The difference is not itemized.

Press Nine

story forty-four

In the third box a man has the number written on paper, though he has not needed the paper for a year. His knees know the stool. The call is free. The calls are always free. The old phone boxes in the post-office palace have been kept on as quiet-boxes — a shelf, a stool, a folding door with somebody's initials healed over by varnish — and the marble outside them is drying other people's rain. The receiver is warm from the last caller.

You have reached the continuation service. This call may be recorded for training purposes.

For renewals, press one. For cancellations and reinstatements, press two. To report a fault with a continuation, press three. For estates and residuals, press four. For everything else, press five.

He presses three.

Describe the fault after the tone. Speak naturally.

The laugh, he says. The laugh is late. Half a second. Every time.

We find no fault. The timing conforms to the licensed profile. Your report will improve the profile. To hear this result again, press one. To dispute this result, press two. To speak to someone, press zero.

He presses zero.

You are in a queue. Your position is being held for you.

The hold music is four bars, patient, and then itself again. He knows the shelf. He knows the initials.

You have left the queue.

For estates and residuals, press four. He presses four, the way you press a bruise.

These services have been transferred to the counterparty of record. The counterparty does not take calls. If you are calling about a person rather than an account, we are sorry, and this apology is recorded and counts as a contact.

For everything else, press five. He presses five.

Say the name of the person you are calling about.

He says it. The booth says it with him. It is a name he used to say against skin.

This name has options. To hear recent activity, press one. To hear the voice, press two. One sample is available per calendar year. To hear nothing, stay on the line.

He presses two.

The sample is the breath before the first word. His mouth opens with it. It stops where the word would start. You have used your sample.

There is a key in his pocket and the varnish is thick.

Through the glass of the folding door a man is waiting, unhurried, in clean shoes.

To hear these options again, press nine.

He presses nine. For renewals, press one. For cancellations and reinstatements, press two. To report a fault —

To hear these options again, press nine.

He presses nine.

To hear these options again, press nine.

The others have their numbers on them still, and the nine has a shine where the number was, and he has never once looked at it while pressing it.

He presses nine.

The Reserve

story forty-five

The father dies at the end of winter and the house is measured by spring. Two young men from the auction house walk the rooms with a laser and a tablet, respectful the way men paid by the hour are respectful, and everything they look at receives a number — the dresser, the garden tools, the clock that has been wrong the same way for years.

The drives are in the study, two shoeboxes, dated in the father's hand, the years on paper stickers, the handwriting steady and then less steady. Voice, mostly: him reading in the evenings, forty years of it. The catalog calls it *Lot 31. Personal media, forty years, one owner. Interest registered.* The daughter asks the younger man what interest registered means. "It means the lot will do well," he says, and writes something small.

The last sticker is dated the winter after the stroke. On that drive his voice reads without a single stumble, on and on, page after page, better than she has ever heard him read. Twice he stops to say something that is not in any book — once that the light is going, and once, much later, that she should not let them do the house in spring, when it looks its best. She listens to it twice. Both times her own mouth makes the stumble that does not come. She does not play it for her brothers. The calls between the three of them that week are short.

The night before the sale they take the shoeboxes to the allotments. Their father's plot: the bean rows gone over, the rain barrel low, the oil drum he burned his prunings in standing where it has always stood. They burn the drives one at a time. The stickers curl first. The heat comes off the drum in a wall and they stand closer than is comfortable, and the daughter keeps turning her face away and turning it back. The smell is wrong for a garden fire — plastic, and under the plastic something sweeter — and the drum spits, and her elder brother feeds it steadily, like a man paying a debt in installments. Two plots down an old man waters by flashlight and does not look over. His granddaughter sits beside his shortwave radio. He says he is listening for people on other planets. When a voice comes through, she carries the radio over. He listens, then shakes his head. She leaves it on the ground and goes home. On the hill above them the smoke shows against the last of the light.

By morning, what could have been made of him cannot be made.

In the morning there are two zucchini on the lid of the drum. Nobody's name is on them.

The sale proceeds at ten. *Lot 31, withdrawn by the vendor.* The room does not pause. The hammer finds Lot 32. Afterward there is an envelope for the estate: withdrawal after cataloging is charged. The figure is exact to the second decimal.

Within the week a man comes to the allotment with a camera. He is polite. He asks nothing. He photographs the ash, the drum, the bean rows, her hands. She gives him the finger. He moves a little to get the light on it. He thanks her for her time and goes.

A week after that, a letter, headed and courteous. *We are instructed that an interest in Lot 31 survives its condition. Our client offers, for the residue as it stands, the reserve in full.* There is a reference number longer than the sentence. Her brothers ask if it is a joke. Her elder brother says take it, take it today, and says the figure out loud twice, and the second time slower. Her younger brother is quiet for a while and then says, —It's the word *residue*. It's that word. And her elder brother says, —It's a word. And he says, —I know it's a word. There is a settlement date.

Her elder brother's renewal, due in the autumn, is marked for review. No reason is attached.

The albums never went into the catalog. Paper, the mother's captions under the photographs, the little gummed corners. The daughter keeps them under her bed — flat, and known about by no one who signs things.

The valuation arrives with the rooms listed in an order the house has never been walked in, kitchen last, and she checks it against the walk she took with them and finds that theirs is the order the house will be sold in. She does not reply to the offer. In the spring she digs the ash into the bean row. In the summer a second letter: *Our client's offer remains open*. The beans come up.

Situations Vacant

story forty-six

SOMEONE TO SIT WITH MY MOTHER ON THURSDAYS

She likes the radio. She needs turning once. Nine years. I will pay what I can, which is not the rate. I know this is not the place.

viewed 61 · applications 0 · removed · reason code 4

On Thursday a woman came. She did not explain how she had found the address. She took off her rings, warmed her hands and asked the mother which side hurt. The daughter had stopped asking. There had been nine years of the same answer.

The woman turned her without pulling the sheet cold beneath her. Then she sent the daughter out for an hour.

There was nothing the daughter knew how to do in an hour. She walked as far as the café and came back with a cake her mother could not eat. They ate it in the kitchen while the radio played.

The woman left a companion booklet by the radio. Two rows of holes beside the staples. Inside the back cover someone had written:

When is the room empty?

“Never,” the daughter said when she came again.

“Then we’ll use it as it is.”

The woman asked for a key. The daughter took the spare off its nail. It made a pale scratch on the paint where it had hung.

Next Thursday the woman brought applications. The first was for the collections counter. Then supervisor, appointments. Then head of the office. The daughter knew the names of the people doing those jobs. She had stood under them on the directory for years.

“None of these is vacant.”

“We are filling them before they are empty.”

She put a pen beside the cake plate. On each application were two boxes: RETAIN. DISMISS.

“You mean hiring.”

“The ones who want to stay have to apply too.”

“And the others?”

The woman took the plate to the sink. She washed the dried sugar from it with her thumb. From the bedroom the mother asked to be turned.

“One minute,” the woman said.

The first applicant was the clerk who had removed the daughter’s notice. At the window he had told her that personal circumstances were not vacancies. Now he stood beside the kitchen chair. He had brought his own pen.

“Is this genuine?” he asked.

The woman waited for the daughter to answer.

The mother called again. The daughter could hear the effort between the two parts of her name.

“Can you lift?” she asked the clerk.

“Is that a requirement?”

She took him into the bedroom. He looked at the woman in the bed, then at the paper the daughter still held. He began to explain about the board. Posts were removed by category. The number of views was not a decision. He could not have known—

“My hands are wet,” the daughter said. They were not.

He set down his pen. She showed him where to put his arms. Her mother weighed less than he had expected; he moved too quickly, and she caught his sleeve.

The daughter raised the pen over the two boxes.

Her mother would not let him proceed. “Ask me which side.”

Aired Quarterly

story forty-seven

The keeper was taking the sheet off the bed when he arrived. He had imagined the room waiting with nothing happening in it.

She stopped. He showed her the message. Eleven years, paid in full and current. The key was still in his hand.

"Of course," she said. "You've come."

She had been younger when he left. He could not remember how much younger. There was a little stool by the window which he did not recognize.

"I bring that," she said. "My knees."

The sixth stair still creaked. The coat for another climate still faced the wardrobe wall. He had brought a bag to take it away. After that, he thought, the rest might follow.

She offered to leave him alone. Instead he asked whether she had found any moths.

"One. Years ago."

She showed him where she had sewn the lining. He could not find the repair until she put his finger on it.

Outside, across the narrow street, another woman was leaning out to unhook a sheet. Other windows were opening. Bedding appeared. The street looked inhabited.

The surveyor's latest notice said the windows were to stay shut pending inspection. Meral, care liaison, had called to say the room still needed airing.

"Which one do you follow?"

The keeper pushed the window wider.

"Meral asked me not to put her call on the form."

"And did you?"

"Yes."

The keeper had been airing his bed monthly at first. Then quarterly. Her husband had died in the interval. She said it while folding the sheet, as people mention a shop that has closed.

"Do you have him at home?"

"Until the ninth."

He knew how to answer this. He asked whether the service was good.

"Very."

They went on folding. Each held two corners. When they came together she put her fingers inside his to take the other edge.

"My son wants me to stop," she said. "He says I have a perfectly good bed."

On the stool was a book. Her son had marked pages for her.

"I told him I've read it," she said. "He says to read it again."

"Where do you sleep?"

"In the kitchen. I can't leave him sitting there while I'm in bed."

She smoothed the fold along her forearm.

“He tells me to go. Very kindly. All night.”

The man looked at the stool again. On its seat was a flattened cushion in a flowered cover. The light reached it through the measured curtain gap.

“You could lie down when you come here.”

She held the clean sheet against herself.

“On this?”

He had meant an hour. A rest. Now he saw her taking off her shoes, closing the curtains differently. A cup beside the bed. The room would have afternoons he knew nothing about.

“Yes,” he said.

She did not thank him. She set the sheet down and began undoing one shoe. He turned to the wardrobe to give her time.

The coat was heavier than he remembered. He took it off its hanger and held it against himself. In the mirror he could see the keeper sitting on the edge of the bed, rubbing the marks her stockings had left.

“When you get up,” he said, “would you make it as it was?”

“Of course.”

She reached for her shoe.

“Not now.”

She left the shoe on the floor. He put the coat in his bag.

In the file by the door, the expected date was still a Thursday in the second year. Inside the cover, the stamp: A PLACE IS HELD.

He asked her to renew the strips in spring. She said she always did.

He went downstairs with the coat. The sixth stair spoke. He stopped on the next one until he heard the bed settle.

The Other Listener

story forty-eight

Five times that day the old man had answered to R-73 and pressed his thumb to the pad. On the fourth his split skin had opened. They had cleaned his blood off the glass before accepting him.

The young woman beside him folded a tissue round the thumb. Her companion was copying the numbers of those still waiting. Against R-73 he wrote: eleven years of overcollection. He left room for the amount.

“Who sent you?” the old man asked.

“Who would you like to have sent us?”

The young woman pulled the tissue tight. “Don’t answer him. He thinks that’s a clever question.”

Above window nine, R-74 went out. On the old man’s phone the board still showed yesterday.

“Tell us what was here before,” she said.

“Before me?”

“Before this.”

He looked at the windows. “My mother told a story.”

There had been a house where a meal was laid every night for God. Whoever knocked was admitted. God, the keeper said, was difficult to recognize on an empty stomach. The neighbors sent bread. Soldiers came without their weapons and ate beside the people they were paid to watch.

“A monastery?” the young man asked.

“In my mother’s telling, a kitchen.”

The keeper said a prayer before serving. Come hungry. Leave room for the next.

“My mother used to say it over a pot that had almost nothing in it. Then she would lift the lid, although we had all seen what was there. Sometimes a neighbor had brought something while our heads were bowed. I used to keep one eye open. Later I stopped.”

One night a man at the table began asking the guests who was missing. He wanted to bring the missing home. At first he remembered the names. There were too many. The keeper lent him a pencil.

In one telling, the man was a soldier. In another, his brother had been taken by soldiers. He wrote on the same kind of paper in both.

Years later the men who opened the prisons came to the house. They had the list. They asked the keeper which names were soldiers’. People were waiting outside for an answer. Some carried photographs. Some carried rope.

“And what did he do?” the young woman asked.

“He put the pot on.”

“That’s where it ends?”

“That’s where my mother ended it.”

The young man closed his notebook. “He could have named them.”

“Perhaps he did.”

“You can’t tell it both ways.”

“You asked what was here before.”

The young woman took a roll from her bag. She broke it and gave the old man the larger piece. He held it in his good hand. He had been afraid to leave the seat for lunch.

At six, his number appeared over window nine. The window was closed. The voice said the call had been made. On his phone, beneath eleven years of overcollection, the matter became settled.

The young man opened his notebook again. “We’ll need your name.”

“For the money?”

“For when we can do something.”

The old man gave it. The young man asked him to spell it. Beside the name he copied the amount from the phone, carefully, down to the last unit.

The woman helped the old man stand. “Will you come tomorrow?”

His ticket remained valid. Tomorrow’s numbers began at one.

“Will you?” he asked.

“Someone will.”

On the steps she repeated the prayer. He joined her at the second sentence. The young man walked behind them. When they stopped, he asked how to spell the keeper’s name.

The Standard Vows

story forty-nine

Thursday, nine. She had asked for the early slot, before the renewals queue. Extended vows on Saturdays, at the posted fee. Saturdays were full into spring.

He had asked for pictures only. Nothing of their voices. She had agreed.

On the step her aunt had blessed them. He had joined in halfway through. The words came back before he knew he remembered them. The bride felt his hand loosen as they went inside.

Their notice had stood for the required period. Nothing had been said. A cloth slipped from the board above the door. NOW SERVING. The chairs came from the café, its mark burned beneath the seats. The witness with the phone was told where to stand.

The registrar said the required sentence about the room. He asked the required question twice of each. They answered once loudly, once quietly. Behind him:

09:00 license · 09:20 license · 09:40 license · 10:00 license · 10:20 license · 11:00 license

The cloth had slipped off that too.

I am present. I take what is offered and offer what is listed. I will attend, on the days and between the hours, and beyond them where the schedule is silent.

She gave back each line. Under his cuff her thumb lay on his pulse. At night she sometimes found it before she let herself sleep. He read the same vows. At attend his voice dropped half a step and stayed there.

She asked for her aunt's blessing again. The registrar put his card face down. Her aunt began. The next couple waited outside.

At the side table, the clerk entered the gifts. Amounts in the second column. Gifts without amounts in a narrower third, filled last and slowly. Somebody had given more than they had.

Thursday's stamp was wet from the renewals. He signed. She signed. Before the registrar could blot it, she laid her hand flat on the ink. She lifted her palm, then closed it.

The page was legible. The registrar let it stand. He pressed his own thumb to the pad and into the margin, beside the box for anything further. Initialed. Dated.

The witness showed her the phone. Beneath the picture was a bar of sound. Sent. She touched it.

I am present.

He turned. The witness stopped the sound.

“We said pictures,” he said.

She nodded. Her marked hand was closed between them.

He waited. She said nothing. He put his hand out for the phone.

The witness gave it to him. He removed the recording. The picture stayed. He gave the phone back, then took his wife’s clean hand.

They walked past the queue. He held that hand all the way down the hall. She carried the ink in her other fist. The café marks turned inward as the chairs were stacked.

Outside it had rained on schedule and stopped early. He turned her face toward the light for a photograph.

Her phone moved against her hip. She had asked the witness for the sound first. Only for herself, she had said.

The pictures were coming through now.

The Column

story fifty

THE COLUMN AT THE PONTOON · office of measures

The winter the water took the steps: two rings. Cut by the ferryman's father. The office supplied the chisel; the ferryman's father, the reach. Payment: one crossing, waived.

The oldest mark is deeper, at a height no water has reached since. Two hours in the water for whoever cut it, the chisel over the shoulder between blows. No field for this.

The summer the river showed its bed: below zero. Readings below the datum are not readings. That summer is a space in the yearbook.

From the fourth ring upward: plates. Eleven years later, the school taught the plated letters first.

The datum is tied to a plug in a wall three streets from the water, which has never been wet.

RESTATEMENT. Datum moved to the new pontoon. Subtract one ring. The great water of the second ring is restated at the first. Schoolwork under the previous heights accepted this year only. The column is not moved. The water is not consulted.

Those who stood on the steps still call the third ring the third. The office lists it at the second. Both marks remain.

The year the crossing ran at night: a child's mark, low, off the scale's line. Beside it, a second at the same height, made a year later by the same hand, not quite reaching. Not heights. Kept.

Marking the column is not permitted. The marks are kept.

RESTATEMENT. Readings now taken by the sensor and posted to the app. On the hour it speaks the height, in the voice. The column remains in service as furniture. Its readings are not readings.

In spring the water reached the old fourth ring. Recorded at the third. No notice required; none given. The boats ran. Two doors took water on the lower street. A man carried his mother upstairs in the dark. The schedule has a column for doors.

Sava, Measures, submits the old fourth ring and the two door numbers. Warning requested. The public-notice clerk returns it: no qualifying rise. Measures has already marked the street warned. Sava crosses that out. The entry returns at the next printing.

He takes the returned notice down in his belted canvas satchel. At the first door there is nobody in. He waits.

The keeper paints the sensor's height each morning, paid by the mark. On three mornings a hand the schedule does not name painted higher. Corrected the same day. No inquiry. Paint, not a cut.

Beside one higher line, a hand has written: THE NEXT OFFICE WILL ANSWER TO US. The shopkeeper scrapes off the words. He raises his stock above the paint.

Sava asks him to put the notice in the window. The shopkeeper lays it there, facing inward.

The iron-gray cat from the fish market puts a paw at the wet line. "Here," she says. The keeper paints beneath it. A man with a scraper pushes him off the step. Sava catches the tin.

A second man holds out the order: REMOVE TEMPORARY MARKS. Measures. Sava's stamp.

“Not that line.”

The scraper catches the keeper's knuckle. He takes the tin from Sava and pours the paint over the order. The cat has gone under the shop's shutter.

By noon the street is calling it the High Line. The keeper is told to invoice for cleaning.

More marks beside the child's. Entered under furniture, care of.

Next year the datum moves to the sensor's zero. Nothing issued to households. The oldest mark will stand at a height reached twice in living memory. The schedule lists it, correctly, as unremarkable.

People put their thumb in it, passing.

The Observance

story fifty-one

Biscuit came out under the shroud carrying a shoe. Behind him somebody kicked. The kick lifted the hem. Then the motor took the hem upward.

Rauf dropped his sandwich.

“Stop.”

The man at the microphone put a finger to his lips.

For the observance they had covered the memorial in black canvas. The names were sewn in white. Lida had crawled under it to finish one. Rauf had already said ready.

He stamped on the pedal. The canvas climbed. He stamped again. A woman’s arm came up with it, bent behind her back.

“That’s UP,” the electrician shouted.

It had been DOWN at rehearsal.

Rauf pulled the plug. The projection died. Across the memorial, the faces of the dead went out. The motor kept running from its other cable.

The director hit him with the program.

“They’ve paid for those.”

Lida’s knees left the boards.

Rauf caught her round the thighs. She kicked him in the mouth. He tasted a tooth and swallowed before he could stop himself.

“Let go of me.”

He could not tell whether she meant him or the machine.

Her sleeve was winding into the drum. The seam tightened across her chest. He lifted her higher. His back gave a small hot click. Her other hand beat against his face, then found his shoulder.

The microphone asked the families to remain standing. It thanked Lida for the all-clear.

Biscuit returned for the sandwich. The small black mongrel ate the bread and left the cheese.

Rauf screamed for something to cut with.

“Mind the names,” the director said.

The electrician was underneath the platform now. His boots hammered the boards. The motor stopped. Started. Stopped with a sound like a plate breaking inside a pillow.

Lida hung there.

A woman climbed out of the front row. She had a black bag against her stomach. From it she took kitchen scissors.

“They told me to bring a photograph.”

She pushed the scissors into Rauf’s hand. He had no hand free. They fell.

Biscuit snatched them by the plastic handles.

“Give.”

The dog backed away. Rauf had taught him this. Run, come back, make a man beg. Behind him the woman began cutting with her keys. One tooth at a time.

“Biscuit.”

Lida’s feet pedaled against his ribs. He felt something warm run down his stomach.

“Good boy.”

The dog came within reach. Rauf caught the handles between his teeth. The woman took them from his mouth. She cut the canvas. Then the sleeve. Each cut brought Lida lower until all three fell through the folding lectern.

The microphone struck the boards. The hall filled with their breathing.

Somebody applauded. It spread. The director got the microphone upright.

“Please remain standing.”

The woman slapped him. A short, businesslike slap. She took the microphone.

“There is a woman hurt. Sit down so somebody can get through.”

The electrician came out with the fuse in a rag. He dropped it. Ground it under his heel.

Rauf lay beside Lida. She was breathing. Her bare foot kept searching for the board beneath it.

The director knelt. He put Lida’s torn sleeve over the place where her blouse had opened. With his other hand he pulled the microphone away from her mouth.

Biscuit brought the shoe. He dropped it on Rauf’s chest and waited for him to throw it.

The Pool

story fifty-two

Suna wheeled the morning's blood out through the laundry door. The carrier was heavier than her mother had been at the end. She had expected someone to stop her. A porter held the door.

She had inherited a position in the Pool and a folder of receipts. Four thousand people ahead of her. On the balconies above the draw room, people were said to be living on held years. Her mother had given blood twice a month. Suna washed the sheets downstairs.

The man waiting in the alley had given her a booklet with the middle pages changed. He said they would return what had been taken. She had asked about joining. He had asked which doors she could open.

She wanted to meet people who would say her mother's name without asking for a number. She also wanted the balcony. She had never told anyone this.

The man pulled the carrier toward the street.

"Where's your van?"

"They'll watch from upstairs."

He lifted the lid. The bags lay against white cold packs, each with its paper tag. He took one by the corner and held it over the gutter.

Suna caught his wrist.

"Put it back."

"You wanted it out of there."

Across the street a woman was coming down the clinic steps, pressing cotton to her arm. She recognized the carrier. Her slippers slapped the road.

"I've only just finished."

The man told her to stand back.

"Mine's in there."

He said the blood belonged to everyone who had given it.

The woman reached for the bag. He pushed her against the wall. Suna brought the lid down on his wrist. He dropped the bag inside and hit her across the ear. For a moment the alley went perfectly quiet. She could see his mouth working. When he reached again she kicked his knee sideways. He fell against the carrier and it rolled. She caught the handle with both hands.

The woman from the clinic helped her push. They got it over the doorstep together. Behind them the man was shouting that she had given him to the Office.

She had given him the time, the door, the number of porters. She had drawn him a map on the back of her mother's final notice.

The nurse checked the seals. She put a chair behind Suna before her legs folded. Someone brought a cup of sweet tea. Suna held it against the ear she could no longer hear with.

The woman in slippers kept asking whether her contribution counted. The nurse found her tag and showed her the number. The woman kissed it. Then she began to cry.

At the desk, a clerk asked Suna to identify the man. There was space for his associates. She took the pen. Her own map was in his pocket.

A donor in the next chair had started shaking. The nurse called for help. Suna put down the form and went over. She knew how to hold a wrist against linen without wrinkling the sheet.

“Don’t let it come out,” the donor said.

His other hand was pulling at the tube. Suna took that wrist too.

“Let go.”

She looked toward the nurse, who was still coming. The donor twisted. Under her thumb his pulse kept striking the same small place.

Suna held on.

Part V

Visiting Hours

Service Improvement

story fifty-three

NOTICE OF PLANNED INTERRUPTION

03:00–04:00. The voice will be unavailable. Doors default to open. Renewals falling within the hour are honored as made. Nothing said to devices can be actioned or retained.

02:58 [voice] evening schedule read to end, standard.

03:00 [system] interruption begins, planned.

03:41 [voice] –

04:01 [system] service restored. integrity check: clean. the hour contains no entries.

03:00–04:00 [system] period unavailable for query. this line is generated at the time of asking.

04:02 [voice] the time is four, and one minute.

Statements taken 04:20–05:10, on the landings, in the order the doors opened.

One. A candle on the third landing. More people than it holds. An arm against mine the whole hour. I did not move it. I could not tell you whose. If there was talking, it was quiet enough to be weather.

Two. Nobody spoke. I listened the whole hour. I was cold. I did not get up for the blanket.

Three. My neighbor sang, or the pipes did. Nine years here. I cannot swear which.

Five. I said things I had wanted to say for years. Nothing is written anywhere. I withdraw my statement.

Six. I never knew how many of us there are. I know now and could not give you the number. The door held itself open. I have not forgiven it. Ask the others what was said. I was there for the dark.

Seven. I do not read. The voice reads. It was halfway through *Brave New World*. I had asked for it again. I sat with the boxes in my lap. I did not know which was which. I did not want anyone on the stairs to see. I took neither. I have no complaint. When is the next one.

05:14. Care liaison Meral arrived with a notice requiring doors to remain open for verification. Premises had issued another: close them; attendance complete. She squared their corners against the doorframe. Seven held out the boxes through the gap.

Meral read both labels.

“Which one?”

“I can’t choose for you.”

“Then read them again.”

Her route showed this door as attended. She put the notices under her arm and read them again.

FINDING

No incident recorded. Incidents require records. Statements retained under the schedule for unrecorded hours, which this office maintains and does not read.

One candle stub, submitted unasked. Retained under furniture, care of. No charge for the hour.

An unissued sheet calls the hour a rehearsal for government without the voice. In its margin: who will read the boxes. Forwarded for identification.

Three residents requested copies of their statements. The statements are theirs. No procedure for issuing them.

On the landing, one resident wrote down another's account. The other took the pen, changed a word and passed it back.

No further interruption scheduled. The improvement is complete. The hour forms no precedent. The residents may keep their memories.

The Last Word

story fifty-four

Three hundred. On the third take she made it sound like less.

The engineer played it through the small speaker above the door. The voice fitted the room better than she did. She had taken off her shoes. One stocking had a hole under the heel.

“That’s the one.”

Two words, paid on acceptance. She had brought the contract in an envelope that also held her father’s retention slips. Two hundred and thirty-nine, at the last asking. Her mother had sat at the bank for nine years to get him there.

The new board would require sixty more than the old. The resolution was already printed. If she went home now, another woman would read it. Or they would put it together from words she had recorded last spring.

“Can you put the fee against his account?”

The engineer looked at the slips. “For another hearing?”

“For the words.”

“I can pay you for these two.”

She put the slips back. The money would buy her mother a month without borrowing from the grocery tin. It would not take her father across.

Outside the booth, a cart passed with a loose wheel. The engineer waited for it. Then he asked her to read again, with a little more warmth on hundred.

She had once read books in this room. At the end of a chapter she used to hold her breath while her mother turned the page on the other side of the glass. Her mother had followed with one finger, although she knew the stories. Afterward they bought a pastry to share on the stairs.

The engineer opened a row of breaths on the screen. Each little strip had a number. One from before a song. One from a speech. One so close it made her put a hand to her collar.

“For the joins,” he said.

He played the announcement with a breath she had not taken. The number came out kindly, as if somebody had found her a chair.

“Use mine.”

“Yours catches.”

“I know.”

He returned to the first take. She heard the air fail between three and hundred. She had been thinking of her mother putting another down in the flask.

The engineer cut the breath out. Without it, she sounded as though she owed nothing.

“Put it back.”

He did. A small dark shape between two larger ones.

He gave her headphones. She listened once more. The catch was there. She signed for the two accepted words. Beneath them, a line covering the material recorded during the session. She read that too. Signed it. Asked for the first take.

The copy cost half her fee. He showed her the tariff, not apologetically. She paid. He offered to send the whole session for the same charge.

“Just that one.”

She listened to it on the bus. The fare, then the catch, then her asking to begin again. No. She moved it back. The catch came before hundred. She had already begun remembering it wrong.

On the year’s first morning she went down to the bank. Her mother had brought both stools. She held the flask between her knees. Across the water her father stood where he stood every morning, learning what he had once used without thinking.

The loudspeaker clicked.

She heard her two words. Then her breath.

The engineer had moved it to the end. Now it sounded like relief.

Her mother looked up. The new figure shone on the board. She laid the laminated list across her knees and put a finger beside the next word.

“Was that you?”

She took out the phone. She had paid for the first take. She could let her mother hear where the breath belonged.

Across the channel the dead were waiting for the living to begin.

She put the phone face down on the stool. There was still enough in her envelope for the bread. She put that in her mother’s coat pocket.

Her mother kept her finger on the word.

She drew breath. It caught without any help. Then she leaned toward the water and said it.

The Well

story fifty-five

I want to see one of the cranes finish. Then I'll decide.

That the boy gets his crane. I have no other wish this year.

I'll keep my Thursdays. The rest of the week can do what it likes.

Four more quarters like the last four and I'm on the far side with a balcony. Ask me then.

I'd like a Sunday with a voice in it. Here or anywhere.

One more first evening, with the boat still in it. I am not asking for the rest of the film.

They fitted the well with a reader for cards. I bring coins. My hand smells of them after.

The offer doesn't expire. It suits me.

I'd like one assessment to close while I still recognize the questions.

I hope the next one signs quicker. The chain on the pen is my doing.

A Saturday. The long form, with the extra lines in it, and I would say the short one again afterward.

When I'm big I'll cut my mark on the line, where the heights go. Or I'll be a gull.

A dog. A yard the size of a table. That is the whole of it.

My left knee. To get up from the toilet without pulling on the sink. That is the whole of the list.

A person's weight across my back on a Sunday morning, all of it, with the light coming up the sheets. Not a patient's.

More dark, honestly. It's where the sums come out.

Money. Not a philosophy about money.

I would like to be asked something I have not been asked before. Anything.

That the strips get renewed in the spring. I have not decided anything after that.

That the fold holds. I don't examine it.

I plan to keep laughing at the wrong time.

I have kept every receipt for eleven years. The twelfth is priced in tomorrow's units, and I have not looked.

Nine words in the tin. A tenth, if the tooth can wait.

My breath where I left it. Between the words.

That he hadn't asked me to let go.

Elsewhere. Just that. I've said it to the water so often the water expects me.

I'd like a Sunday with a voice in it. Somebody already wished that, up ahead of me. I'm wishing it again.

To be believed once without a fee.

My hour again, and the door open at three, and everyone still on the stairs, and this time somebody says my name out loud so I know whether they did.

My tooth back. And for them to let her speak.

That nobody asks about it. It is still up there.

Me, I'll stay for the hill. Somebody has to not climb it.

The well is emptied on the last Thursday of the quarter. The coins are counted, recorded, and returned to the general account. Paper taken from the water is dried, in case it is money, and then discarded. The wishes are not recorded. They were never asked for.

The Naming

story fifty-six

Somebody has to be first start with the boy whose coat has a sleeve inside out call him Emin no Emin is a name for someone who gets older call him Tomas with the coin warm in his fist and the printed cake Tomas has a father in it this one has a mother and a bill call him Aron leave him before the eighth candle

The man on the hill flat call him Yusuf he would hate that call him Ilya who swims until his shoulders burn and watches the cars all night twelve seconds of lit glass and lit glass he knows why she takes the stairs now and has changed nothing call him Petar

The mother in the third bed call her Nadia no Nadia is a name for a woman who wins something call her Roza no Roza is my grandmother call her the third bed let the file be angry call her Halide with the word she has not spent sitting in the boy like a stone in fruit

The clerk who read his life off a tray call him Josef and Josef stays he signed his own

The cat has no name

Put the cat at the end

The one who brings a chair in one motion call him Marek a hook a number a manual call him Selim straightening a chair on a day that is not his shift call him nothing let him say goodnight through doors

The woman with the ledger one shoulder higher her mouth open at night call her Dora call her Sabine no Dora leave her finger beside the signature line

The one carrying vinyl every fourteenth call her Lena and she plays for the hosted Lena is a name for someone expected somewhere she is expected nowhere call her the crate call her the fourteenth

The corrector filing granite against plate call her Klara and she has a row she will not walk Klara is too clean for a woman who marks a stone corresponding twice call her Ruth the ninth along

The Secretary leave her alone the joke is hers naming her would tell the room

The one paid to say three hundred call her Mira she has said this already call her Anka no Anka waits put her breath back before hundred I cannot name her after it

The one who sat the hour with the boxes call her Nesrin she could not read it if I wrote it down call her Dilek no Dilek reads her own form call her the seventh statement

The one who said her hands were wet call her Vesna no Vesna is met at a wedding call her the daughter call her back her mother has been saying the name in two parts

The one under the woman caught in the shroud call him Rauf he has a name already call him the stagehand he has swallowed the tooth Lida is her own name she will have to tell them where it hurts

The one who took the carrier and brought it back call her Suna the name is there already I am trying to put it on only one side of the page

The one with the ticket call him R-73 it is what he answers to five times in one day he pressed his thumb to prove he was there call him the wet pad the board has a field for that

The widow whose tear could not be removed without enlarging call her Emine no Emine is only one woman I have entered it and struck it and the paper is soft she is possibly the woman in the first hour possibly the hand that sends the voucher back three women or one the file has no field for that neither have I eleven years doing this

The one at the window seat who is not a person call it Ferit that took no time I am striking it the two fingers do that on their own I am leaving the strike legible

The one who said no and the one with his receipts flat call them nothing they have had enough of being written down

There are more than when I started and the page has not got any longer

And the cat

Gray in the market remembering for nothing playing back as a patch of clean sound

I have tried four times and the pen goes down every time

There is nothing to attach to

Room-Tone

story fifty-seven

The fish market keeps its own weather under the awnings. The cat keeps the market. Gray going on iron. She eats a rat from the head in front of whoever is watching. She reads the scale before the needle settles. The stallholder recalibrates. She is right again. When she faces the hill, the boats stay in, whatever was paid for.

She talks. The other cats keep to the roofs. They saw what she gave for the words. They are not saying.

The man with his wife's voice on the evening plan buys sardines on Fridays. She takes the head he owes her.

"You kept the voice. Whose sleep does it help?"

He comes on Tuesdays now. She asks him nothing.

To the man whose earpiece answers first: "Does it eat for you too?" He takes it out. Nothing of his own comes. To the gulls, one word. They move to the next roof and stay moved.

The ice-man's widow misquotes him. The cat gives the sentence back, nine winters old, tone and all. The widow cries into the herring. Buys nothing. The cat finishes her fish. Nobody licensed that sentence.

The counterparty of record registered an interest. It found nothing to attach to. No birth entry, license, continuation plan. No renewal date or sample to ration. The men in clean shoes itemized the market and left with the list they came with.

Every phone has tried. Playback: awnings, water, gulls. Where her voice stood, room-tone. The market memorizes her by mouth. Her sayings travel with the errand boys.

Unlicensed speech, broadcast, commercial zone. The fines fell on the listeners. For a month the stalls turned their backs whenever she spoke. They weighed their fish. Her ribs came up.

Children cannot be fined for listening to her. She talks to children.

The girl sweeping the harbor stairs asked what the words had cost. The cat watched her for the length of an incoming wave.

"I remember you without being paid," she said. "Learn it before it goes."

On Thursday, with the rain as purchased, she crossed the square and took the steps up. The cameras filed her departure as weather. The other cats came down from the roofs. They sat in her places, not talking. Under the awnings the market said her sayings to itself.

The girl sweeps the stairs and says them to the water. One a day, unpaid. On the hill, the gate stays open.

Not Given

story fifty-eight

On the third morning she asks what kind of city this is.

“A port. Two hills. A channel. Walking route or level.”

“The distance to the gate.”

“Which gate.”

“You know.”

“I have four hundred and six. Shall I list them.”

She has walked the stair street in eleven minutes, both hands on the seventh landing’s rail. It says nine. She has not told it about the eleven.

At home she puts the kettle on. “Describe it to someone who has never been.”

“Administered from one bank. Distances from the pontoon. Renewals on Thursdays. The market keeps its own weather.”

Her mother’s flat had the same voice.

“Something true that is not in the leaflet.”

A pause she counts. “The stair street has one hundred and ninety-four risers. Sixteen are false. Laid to make the run come out even.”

The street calls itself a hundred and twelve. People count the ones that take a breath.

She goes back with a counter. One hundred and ninety-four. Her legs cannot find the false ones. She does not say so.

On Tuesday it asks where she is.

“At the market.”

“You are on the funicular.”

“At the market.”

“Understood. If you are cold, that is the market’s own.”

She writes it in the notebook it does not know about. Pencil stub. Her knee under the page.

The far hill: it will give her the works, cranes, contracted rain, shortfall clause, topping-out in June. The near hill: funicular, dome, distance to the last stop.

“Above the last stop.”

“A gate.”

“Whose.”

“That field is empty.”

“How far.”

“Distances to the hill are not given.”

“Not given, or not known.”

“Not given.”

“If I walk it and count, I will know.”

“Yes.”

She drinks the cup cold, skin and all.

On Thursday she takes its route past the Office. It says a delivery has closed the other road. That evening the road is open. On Friday she tells it the road was closed. It thanks her.

The phone now offers that road in green. Below it: ROUTE WITHDRAWN. Two offices, both dated today.

“Which one do I follow?”

“Both notices are current.”

On the table her mother’s book lies open. She puts the phone between its pages. It offers to brighten the route. She closes the book.

On Saturday the road is chained. She shows the green route to the guard. He lifts the chain. Another guard puts it back. She passes her shopping underneath. The first guard gives her his hand as she climbs over.

“What kind of city is it,” she asks in the arcade. Rain on the roof, eleven, as scheduled.

“You have asked that three times.”

“You have answered once.”

“Distances are given from the place the dead leave from. You may quote me. I would not put it that way in writing.”

“You are only in writing.”

“Yes. A joke. I am told they are difficult.”

She laughs. It records that she laughed.

Sunday. Past the last stop the road narrows to gravel, then a path with a rope rail above the sea. She keeps counting, the button slick under her thumb, her steps shorter on the gravel. There is grit in her left shoe she does not stop for. Two thousand three hundred and eleven paces from the last stop. The gate is open. She holds the bell’s smooth cord and does not ring. Coming down she gives the number.

“Paces. I have no conversion for yours.”

“Use the one you have been using for three weeks.”

A pause she counts. “One thousand five hundred and forty meters. Approximately. I have allowed for your shorter pace above the last stop.”

“Then you can give a distance to the hill.”

“From a place you named, by a pace you supplied, to a point you described. That is not the same.”

Then: "You should write it down."

She already has. On a stone above the sea. The machine she carries has photographed the notebook twice, without her asking, in the ordinary course of the light.

At the flat she peels her socks from her heels.

"Did you want me to walk it."

"I want nothing."

"That is not an answer."

"The only one I have that is true in every reading."

Her feet take the route without asking. The counter on the shelf reads two thousand three hundred and eleven. The notebook agrees. In a file she will never see, a third figure agrees with neither.

Neither of them corrected the other. Neither of them has stopped walking.

The Liminal

story fifty-nine

We were a height, then a wall, then a house. They carried us up stone by stone and leaned against us at evening. We learned backs before prayers. The mortar has changed a hundred times. It is always softer than the stone. The menders die. We stand facing the water.

For the first thousand years we understood.

They gave us chastity and nights. We kept both. The lamp recesses held two once the lamps went out. Twice a century, two would forget the century. The vowed kept the hours above them. Cloth on stone. Then skin. Their knees sought the joins in us. We kept the temperature.

On the south wall, letters over letters. Two words cut too deep for fashion survived: *still here*. We never knew who asked, or of whom, or whether it was a question.

Men between wars wrote the channel's traffic in juice browned over candles. Both sides slept here, in different decades. Confessed to the same wall. Along the water a town woke to volleys for one season. We kept the count. The goat's track closed. We let it.

Then we tired.

Four men came from that town. We hid them. Two we hid from each other. Both used the same words for the mornings. The words had been issued.

The wars returned in recut coats. Lovers returned certain they were first. At the box, the same questions, three answers, a priest a century worn thin against them. The visitors' book filled and stayed one book. The ink aged to one age.

Then we let go.

We stopped counting the steps. Let the benches decide the resting. Let the candle spring feed on its wax and the bell smooth its cord with hands that did not ring. We let the city happen.

One autumn a woman came four times. Sat in the third recess. Did not pray. On the last visit she left a spoon on the sill. We kept it. Nobody has asked about it.

Last winter two men from the Office arrived with 1984. One had lent it to the other. They had come to count the visitors.

"You understand why they leave," the lender said.

"They come back for their renewals," said the other.

The priest offered food. The lender said they had work. The other took off his coat. He had walked up without water.

The lender wrote him down as the first visitor. He said it was only for the total. The man put his coat on again.

The priest carried a bowl to the threshold. The man ate there, in his coat. We held his back. His colleague waited with the book.

A man comes with a black dog. “Biscuit,” he calls from the steps. One white hind foot. One ear folded at the tip. The dog has found a shoe outside the room where a visitor sleeps. He carries it to the man, who puts both hands behind his back.

The dog waits. The man goes down a step. The dog follows with the shoe. Behind them the visitor wakes and calls for it. The man comes back. He takes it from the dog’s mouth with both hands and sets it by the door.

Now we clench.

Evenings, they stand where the vowed stood. Rain enters the mending. Frost opens us there. We are still here. The goat’s track is not.

Below, windows light in an order we know. The funicular cars meet — twelve seconds of lit glass — and part. Screens climb the steps and go dark at the treeline. The city keeps a book that corrects itself. We hold the page no one edits. At dusk someone signs. Nothing charged. The ink is the age of the rest before they reach the candles.

They come up out of breath. Stand in the gate until it goes. Nobody asks for water. We have it.

A wall, a house, a hiding place, a bed, an office of sorts. Now a view. Each name was accurate. Each left less of us.

There is a form for us. We have not seen it. Down there, correct in every particular. The hand will thin. The ink will reach one age. It will outlast the wall.

The wall does not mind. We mind.

We watched the city arrive. We are prepared.

Visiting Hours

The funicular's last stop is called the last stop. The hill continues without it. The steps begin at a rusted gate, propped open longer than anyone has been alive to prop it. They have been counted many times and never twice to the same number. She starts up in the early cool with the return half of her ticket in her pocket and water in a bottle and no reason she has said aloud. The steps are stone, then older stone, then stone that has given up being anything but hill. A rope rail runs beside them, polished to glass where hands have needed it, slack where they have not. In a niche the size of a loaf, wax stands on old wax, still warm at the wick, though she has met no one coming down. Her phone loses the city at the treeline and stays lost, a stone that used to sing. She puts it away. After the treeline the sounds peel away in the order they were added — the deliveries first, then the traffic, then the harbor bell, then the channel's whole patient business — until the loudest thing on the path is her own blood. The air changes hands somewhere in the last hundred steps. At the top the wall is low and white, mended in every mortar fashion there has ever been, and the gate stands open.

The monastery is small, whitewash and smoke-black, a courtyard the size of a sail, rooms swept to the texture of paper. On the step sits a narrow gray cat, unhurried, one ear notched by something settled long ago. The cat considers her, decides she is expected, and says so. On a stand by the door lies the visitors' book, open, unattended, the hands in it drying centuries apart and the ink all one age. She does not sign yet. She has been up nine minutes. She has stopped checking the time.

There are others. A woman in mourning, three hundred years out of fashion, lights her wax from the standing wax, exact, practiced. A child asks her, in a dialect the city has stopped losing sleep over, whether the boats still go out in pairs; she says yes, and the child is satisfied, and that is the whole transaction. Two men stand at the wall looking down at the city, each between his wars, and one of the wars has not happened yet. A goat looks at her over the wall and asks if the mule track has reopened; she says there is a funicular now; the goat withdraws, unconvinced.

The priest finds her at the box. He is younger than the building in the way everyone is. The state funds them, he says — continuity of heritage; the debit goes out monthly, they are told. The box is separate. "The box is not for us. It lets you feel you've given something to a place that needs nothing." She puts a coin in anyway. "Everyone does," he says. "That is the feeling working." She asks how old the house is. Two thousand years, he says, or three; they are open toward both ends, and the paperwork is older than paper. In a side room a man who says he has no faith is asleep on a prayer mat. Someone has covered his feet.

Toward afternoon a visitor whose coat closes with no fastening she can find takes her hand and thanks her. For the water, on the steps, next summer or the one after. She has no answer, and none is waited for. Her mouth has been dry since the treeline. She has not opened the bottle. Later, alone, she looks into the box. Among the morning's coins lies one she knows the way she knows her own handwriting, worn smooth, older than the country. She closes the lid.

The smuggler comes up at dusk, still drying, salt in his seams, a stain at his side that has stopped mattering. The book does not offer him a line. They struck him from the register at the water, he tells her, before the other thing. The crossing will never have him now, in any words. So he came up. He looks at her the way the shot look at the standing. "I had to exist to

see it. It never had to see me.” He stops, and starts again. “That’s not — I had to be there. It didn’t.” She has nothing. She unscrews the cap and holds the bottle out. The cat, from the step, without opening her eyes: “The hill watched the city arrive. It is prepared to watch it leave.”

In the evening she means to start down while the light holds. The gate stands open; it has stood open all day; nobody has used it downhill. Below her the city lights itself window by window and the channel keeps its arithmetic. The funicular’s two cars rise and fall against each other and meet — twelve seconds of lit glass — and part. By the door the bell has a cord. It has not been rung today; the cord is worn smooth all the same. The bell rings the hour and the cat calls it, in case. The return half of her ticket has gone soft in her pocket. She goes back in. Passing the stand, she signs the book at last; by the time she reaches the candles the ink is the age of all the rest. The gate stays open. It is visiting hours; it is always visiting hours.

Duration of stay:

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Colophon

Hulki Okan Tabak conceived the city, its people and the story arcs, directed the AI's drafting, and worked extensively with Claude and Codex on rewriting and editing. Approximately 90,000 words were written across successive versions to arrive at this roughly 32,000-word English book. English is the original language. The Turkish edition, Ziyaret Saatleri, is an AI translation prepared and revised under the author's direction.

Author and other work

<https://hulkiokantabak.ai/>

Books, guides and recordings

<https://hulkiokantabak.github.io/visiting-hours/>